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Literature in English: The Complete Study Guide

Prose, drama and poetry: methods for the UTME and set-book study

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Chapter 1: What Literature Is

Every society that has ever existed has told stories, sung songs and staged performances. A grandmother in Ibadan who tells children a tale of a clever tortoise under the moonlight, a market woman in Kano who sings the praises of her trade, and a student in Lagos who reads a novel on a danfo bus are all taking part in the same ancient human activity: the making and sharing of literature. This chapter lays the foundation for the whole book. It explains what literature is, how it differs from other kinds of writing, why the subject is divided into three genres, what literature does for individuals and societies, and how oral and written traditions relate to one another.

Literature in English as an examination subject asks you to do more than recognise names and plots. It asks you to understand how writers shape language to produce meaning and feeling, and to explain that understanding in clear, precise terms. The vocabulary introduced here will be used in every later chapter, so read it carefully and return to it often.

1.1 Defining literature

The word *literature* comes from the Latin *littera*, meaning a letter of the alphabet. In its widest sense, literature means everything that has been written down: tax forms, textbooks, advertisements and newspaper reports. In the sense used in this subject, however, literature means

imaginative or creative writing that uses language artistically to explore human experience. It includes novels, short stories, plays and poems and, as we shall see, the spoken and performed art forms of cultures that did not depend on writing.

No single definition satisfies everyone, but most critics agree that literary works share several qualities.

- **Artistic use of language.** The writer selects words for their sound, rhythm, suggestion and surprise, not only for their plain meaning. A weather report says that the sky was dark; a literary writer may say that evening dragged a black cloth across the roofs of the town.
- **Imaginative content.** Literature may be based on real events, but it recreates them through invention, selection and arrangement. Even a story about a real market day is shaped by a writer who decides what to include, what to omit and how to order events.
- **Concern with human experience.** Literature deals with love, loss, ambition, fear, justice, family, power and belief. It shows how it feels to live through events, not only what happened.
- **Universal significance.** A good work speaks beyond its immediate setting. A story about a trader in Onitsha may move a reader in Glasgow because the trader's hopes and worries are recognisably human.
- **Aesthetic value.** Literary works are enjoyed for their form and beauty, not merely for usefulness. The pleasure they give is part of their purpose.

- **Durability.** Great works continue to be read and reinterpreted long after the circumstances of their creation have passed.

> **Key point.** Literature is the artistic expression of human experience through language, whether spoken or written. What marks a text as literary is not that it is old, long or difficult, but that its language and structure are deliberately crafted to create meaning, emotion and pleasure.

Literary and non-literary language

Non-literary writing, such as a recipe or a user manual, aims at clarity and efficiency; it prefers one meaning per word, the *denotative* or dictionary meaning. Literary language often exploits *connotation*, the feelings and associations that cling to words. The word *home* denotes a place where one lives, but it connotes warmth, belonging and safety. A writer who describes a "cold house" instead of a "cold home" has made a deliberate choice that changes the emotional effect.

Literary language also tolerates, and often relies on, ambiguity: a line may carry more than one meaning at once, and good readers enjoy discovering them. Finally, it draws attention to itself through figures of speech, sound patterns, unusual word order and structural design. These features are studied in detail in Chapters 3, 5 and 7.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.1

Decide which of the following passages is more literary and give reasons. (A) "The bus leaves Ibadan at 6 a.m. and arrives in Lagos at 8:30 a.m. The fare is ₦3,500." (B) "The bus coughed itself awake in the grey Ibadan dawn and carried its sleepy cargo toward the roaring mouth of Lagos."

Solution: Passage A states facts directly and uses words in their plain, denotative senses; its purpose is to inform. Passage B uses personification ("coughed itself awake"), metaphor ("roaring mouth of Lagos"), imagery ("grey Ibadan dawn") and rhythm, and it creates a mood. It uses language artistically to evoke an experience. Therefore passage B is the more literary.

1.2 The three genres of literature

A **genre** is a category of literary work, distinguished by its form, conventions and typical subject matter. The word comes from the French for "kind". Literature is traditionally divided into three major genres: prose, drama and poetry. Each has sub-genres, and writers often blend genres, but the three-part division remains the basis of both teaching and examination.

Prose

Prose is language in its ordinary grammatical flow, arranged in sentences and paragraphs rather than in metrical lines. Prose is the natural medium of speech and everyday writing, but literary prose is carefully shaped. Its main forms are:

- **Prose fiction:** the novel, the novella and the short story, which narrate invented events.
- **Prose non-fiction:** biography, autobiography, the essay, the travelogue, the memoir and the diary. These deal with facts but may be written with considerable literary skill.

Prose fiction is the subject of Chapters 2 and 3. In an examination, you will meet prose as a set text and as an unseen passage.

Drama

Drama is literature written to be performed by actors before an audience. The word comes from a Greek word meaning "action" or "deed". A play exists in two forms: the written script, which may be read, and the performance, in which words are joined by movement, costume, lighting, sound and the presence of live players. The playwright works through dialogue and stage directions rather than through a narrator. Drama's sub-genres, including tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce and melodrama, are studied in Chapters 4 and 5.

Poetry

Poetry is the most concentrated form of literary expression. It arranges words in lines, usually with attention to rhythm, sound, imagery and compression of meaning. Poetry may rhyme or not; it may follow strict patterns or none. What defines it is the intensity with which it uses language: every word, pause and line break is felt to matter. Its principal forms include the sonnet, ode, elegy, ballad, epic, lyric and dramatic monologue, discussed in Chapters 6 and 7.

Comparing the three genres

Feature	Prose	Drama	Poetry
Basic unit	Sentence and paragraph	Speech and scene	Line and stanza
Chief medium	Narration and description	Dialogue and action	Imagery, rhythm and sound
Mode of reception	Usually read silently	Seen and heard in performance	Read aloud or silently, often chanted or sung
Typical length	Short to very long	Fixed by performance time	Usually short, sometimes very long (epic)
Voice	Narrator or narrators	Characters speak for themselves	A speaker or persona

Key point. Genre boundaries are not rigid. A prose poem uses the rhythm of poetry in unbroken lines; a verse drama is a play written in poetry; a novel may contain letters, songs or scripts. Always identify the dominant genre, then note any mixing.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.2

Name the genre of each extract and justify your answer. (i) "ADA: You promised you would come. / BAYO: The road was flooded. (He looks away.) / ADA: The road is always flooded when it suits you." (ii) "Rain on the zinc roof, / my mother counting coins, / the radio singing low." (iii) "When the rains came early that year, Mama Kudi knew the farm would not wait for her sons to return from the city."

Solution: (i) is drama: it consists of speakers named in capitals, dialogue and a stage direction in brackets. (ii) is poetry: short lines, compressed imagery, no developed narrative sentence, and attention to sound ("zinc", "coins", "singing low"). (iii) is prose fiction: a narrator tells events in grammatical sentences and refers to characters in the third person.

1.3 Functions of literature

Why do societies value literature? The question has been debated since ancient times. The following functions are the ones most often cited and most often tested.

Entertainment

The first and most obvious function is pleasure. People read novels, attend plays and listen to poems because these experiences are enjoyable. Entertainment is not a trivial function: stories make long journeys shorter, hard evenings gentler and communal gatherings livelier. In traditional Nigerian societies, moonlight story sessions were among the central entertainments of village life.

Education and instruction

Literature teaches. It transmits knowledge, history and values from one generation to the next. A folktale about a greedy character who is punished teaches children the cost of greed more memorably than a lecture could. Proverbs compress practical wisdom into a single sentence. The Roman critic Horace summed up the dual function of entertainment and instruction by saying that literature should both delight and teach.

Moral guidance and social criticism

Writers often act as the conscience of society. Satire exposes foolishness and corruption by making them laughable; tragedy shows the consequences of pride or injustice; protest poetry gives voice to the oppressed. Literature does not simply preach, but it invites readers to judge conduct, weigh motives and reconsider accepted ideas. A writer who describes the suffering caused by a dishonest official makes readers feel the injury in a way statistics cannot.

Preservation of culture and history

Literature is a society's memory. Oral genres such as praise poetry, genealogies and epics preserved the history of lineages and kingdoms long before archives existed. Written works record customs, speech patterns, beliefs and turning points in history. When a language or custom begins to disappear, literature may be the means by which it survives.

Emotional release and self-discovery

By identifying with characters, readers explore their own feelings safely. A reader who has lost a parent may find comfort in an elegy that gives shape to grief. Aristotle called the emotional release produced by tragedy *catharsis*, a purging of pity and fear. Reading also develops empathy: to understand a character is to practise seeing the world from another person's position.

Language development and mobilisation

Reading literature enlarges vocabulary, sharpens sentence sense and trains the imagination. Literature can also arouse people to action: songs, pamphlets, plays and poems have rallied communities during struggles for independence and reform, and have affirmed ethnic and national identity. Nigerian writers in English have shown how the language can carry the rhythms, proverbs and idioms of local speech, enriching English as well as expressing Nigerian life.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.3

A short play shows a village head who accepts bribes from a contractor, causing a bridge to collapse and a child to be injured. At the end the audience laughs at his foolish excuses, then falls silent as the injured child is carried across the stage. Identify two functions this play serves.

Solution: First, social criticism and moral guidance: the play exposes corruption and shows its human cost, inviting the audience to condemn it. Second, entertainment combined with emotional release: the comic excuses amuse, while the closing image produces pity and reflection. A further function is education, since audiences learn the practical danger of dishonesty in public office.

1.4 Oral literature

Oral literature (sometimes called orature) is literature that is composed, performed and passed on by word of mouth rather than through writing. It is not "primitive" or "pre-literary"; it is a sophisticated art with its own rules, specialists and audiences. In Africa it has been the main literary tradition for thousands of years, and it remains alive in festivals, ceremonies, markets, places of worship, radio programmes and popular music.

Main forms of oral literature

- **Folktales:** narratives told for entertainment and instruction, often featuring animal characters (the tortoise, the hare, the spider), human heroes or supernatural beings. They usually carry a moral and often end with a closing formula.
- **Myths:** sacred narratives that explain the origin of the world, a people, a custom or a natural feature, and typically involve deities.
- **Legends:** stories about historical or semi-historical heroes, founders and events, mixing fact with embellishment.
- **Proverbs:** short, memorable sayings that express shared wisdom, such as "a single hand cannot lift a heavy load". Skilful proverb use is, in many African cultures, a mark of eloquence and maturity.
- **Riddles:** puzzling questions that test wit and often precede or follow storytelling sessions.
- **Songs:** lullabies, work songs, funeral dirges, war songs, love songs, praise songs and satirical songs.

- **Chants and incantations:** poetic forms used in ritual, divination, hunting, healing and festivals.
- **Praise poetry (panegyric):** poetry that celebrates the achievements, lineage and attributes of a person, an occupation, an animal or a deity, performed by trained praise-singers or bards.
- **Epics:** long narrative performances recounting the exploits of heroes and founders, often performed over several nights with music.
- **Ritual theatre:** masquerades, festival pageants, puppet plays and storytelling performances that combine speech, dance, music, mime and costume.

Characteristics of oral literature

- **Performance.** An oral work lives only when performed. The performer's voice, gestures, timing and costume are part of the art.
- **Audience participation.** Audiences respond with chorus lines, claps, songs, comments and corrections. A tale told in a village square is a shared event, not a private reading.
- **Communal ownership.** Most oral works have no single known author; they belong to the community and are adapted by each performer. Variation is normal and valued.
- **Memory and formula.** Because the works are not written down, they rely on repetition, parallelism, refrains, stock phrases and rhythmic patterns that help performers remember and audiences follow.

- **Flexibility.** Performers adjust length, emphasis, humour and topical references to suit the occasion and audience.
- **Functional integration.** Oral literature is woven into life: lullabies soothe, dirges mourn, work songs coordinate effort, and praise poetry honours a chief at his installation.

Key point. Oral literature is distinguished by performance, audience participation and communal ownership. Its weakness is vulnerability: when a performer dies without passing on the art, a work may be lost. Its strength is adaptability and direct contact with the audience.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.4

An evening storyteller in a village begins, "Once upon a time, as the elders say...", then pauses while the children respond with an agreed phrase. She sings a short song in the middle of the tale and the children join in. Which characteristics of oral literature does this illustrate?

Solution: The opening formula and the agreed response show formula and call-and-response; the children's participation shows audience involvement; the song shows the integration of music with narration; and the phrase "as the elders say" shows communal ownership and transmission across generations. The whole event shows that oral literature depends on live performance.

1.5 Written literature

Written literature is composed and preserved in writing and, since the invention of printing, reproduced in print and now in digital form. Its development has several consequences.

- **Fixity.** Once printed, a text remains the same from reader to reader. This gives the work a definite form and a known author.
- **Individual authorship.** Written literature tends to be associated with a named author who owns the work, claims credit for it and may develop a personal style.

- **Reach.** Books travel across space and time. A novel written in Enugu can be read in Toronto fifty years later.
- **Private reading.** Reading is often a silent, individual activity, which allows complex structures, long narratives and dense language that would be hard to follow by ear.
- **Experimentation.** Writers can play with page layout, time-shifts and complicated structures because the reader may go back and re-read.

Oral and written traditions compared

Feature	Oral literature	Written literature
Medium	Spoken, sung, chanted, performed	Written, printed, digital
Authorship	Usually communal or anonymous	Usually individual and named
Form	Variable; changes with each performance	Fixed once published
Audience	Present, participating	Absent, reading privately
Preservation	Memory and repeated performance	Books, libraries, archives, electronic files
Risk	Loss when performers die	Loss through decay, censorship or neglect

The relationship between the two traditions

The two traditions are not rivals; they influence each other continuously. Many written works draw on oral forms: a novelist may build a plot on a folktale pattern, use proverbs in dialogue, adopt the rhythm of praise

poetry or place a storyteller within the narrative. A poet may write in the manner of a dirge or a chant. Equally, written works are performed, recorded and broadcast, so that they re-enter the oral world. Modern popular music, radio drama and stand-up comedy continue the oral tradition in new media. Understanding this relationship is particularly important for African literature (Chapter 8).

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.5

A novelist writes a story in which an old woman settles a village quarrel by telling a tale, then sums up the lesson with a proverb. Explain what this shows about the relation between oral and written literature.

Solution: The novel is a written work, yet it contains oral elements: the tale-telling event, the proverb and the communal setting. This shows that written literature can absorb oral materials and techniques, preserving them in print and giving them to readers beyond the original community. The two traditions are complementary, not opposed.

1.6 The writer, the text and the reader

Every literary event involves three elements: the writer (or performer), the text and the reader (or audience). Different approaches to criticism emphasise different elements. Some critics study the **writer**: the life, background and intentions behind the work (the biographical approach).

Some study the **text** itself: its words, structure and devices (close reading). Some study the **society** represented in the work: class, gender, politics, colonialism. Some study the **reader's response**.

For the UTME and school examinations, the most useful habit is a balanced one: begin with the text and what it actually says and does, then bring in background knowledge about the writer, period and society when it helps explain the text. Opinions must always be supported by evidence from the text.

Key terms to know from the start

- **Theme:** the central idea explored in a work (for example, ambition, betrayal, the cost of tradition).
- **Plot:** the arrangement of events in a story or play.
- **Setting:** the time and place of the action.
- **Tone:** the writer's attitude to the subject, such as serious, ironic or tender.
- **Mood:** the feeling a work creates in the reader, such as gloom, suspense or joy.
- **Persona:** the speaking voice created by a poet, which should not be confused with the poet.
- **Imagery:** language that appeals to the senses.
- **Figure of speech:** a deliberate departure from literal language for effect.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.6

A short poem opens: "I am the clerk who counts other men's money / and goes home with an empty pocket." A student writes: "The poet is poor and works in a bank." Explain the error and correct it.

Solution: The student has confused the poet with the persona. The "I" is a speaking voice created by the poet; the poem tells us about the speaker, a poorly paid clerk, but proves nothing about the poet's own life. A correct statement is: "The persona is a clerk who handles other people's money but remains poor, which suggests themes of inequality and frustration."

1.7 What the examination expects

The Literature in English examination tests three broad abilities: knowledge, comprehension and appreciation. Knowledge means that you know the terms, the types and your set texts. Comprehension means that you can follow the meaning of an unseen passage, poem or extract. Appreciation means that you can explain how and why a writer's language produces its effect. These abilities build on this chapter: you cannot discuss a metaphor without knowing what a figure of speech is, or identify a tragedy without knowing how drama is classified.

Three working principles will serve you throughout. First, read actively: pencil in hand, ask what is happening, who is speaking and why the writer chose these words. Second, support every claim with evidence.

Third, keep a vocabulary notebook of every term as you meet it, with an original example of your own.

Exercise 1.1

1. Define literature in one sentence and give two features that distinguish literary from non-literary writing.
2. Name the three major genres of literature and give one sub-form of each.
3. Which genre is written primarily to be performed before an audience?
4. State the difference between denotation and connotation, using the word "snake" as an example.
5. Give three functions of literature and illustrate any one of them with an example from everyday Nigerian life.
6. List four characteristics of oral literature.
7. Identify the genre: "The generator coughed twice and died. In the sudden dark, Mama Tunde laughed and reached for her lantern."
8. Explain why a proverb can be regarded as a piece of oral literature.
9. State two advantages of written literature over oral literature and one disadvantage.
10. A student says, "The speaker in this poem is sad, so the poet must be sad." Why is this reasoning unsafe?

Answers to Exercise 1.1

1. Literature is the artistic expression of human experience through language. It differs from non-literary writing by its artistic use of language (connotation, figures, rhythm) and its imaginative concern with human experience.
2. Prose (novel), drama (tragedy), poetry (sonnet); any valid sub-form is acceptable.
3. Drama, because it is meant to be acted and seen as well as read.
4. Denotation is the dictionary meaning (a limbless reptile); connotation is the associated feeling (danger, treachery). Calling a person "a snake" uses the connotation.
5. For example: entertainment (moonlight tales), education (folktales teaching honesty), preservation of culture (praise poetry recording lineages). Any three with a valid illustration.
6. Any four of: performance, audience participation, communal ownership, formula and repetition, flexibility, functional integration.
7. Prose fiction: narrative sentences, a narrator and a third-person character.
8. A proverb is a short artistic saying, passed by word of mouth, expressing communal wisdom in figurative language; it has no single author and lives in speech.
9. Advantages: fixity of form and wider reach (also named authorship, permanence). Disadvantage: it loses the live audience participation and flexibility of oral performance (or it can be lost through neglect or censorship).

10. It confuses the persona with the poet; the speaker is a voice created for the poem and may not reflect the poet's own feelings.

Chapter summary

- Literature is the artistic expression of human experience through spoken or written language; it is marked by crafted language, imagination, human concern and lasting value.
- Literary language relies on connotation, figures of speech and structure, in contrast with the plain, informative language of non-literary writing.
- The three major genres are prose, drama and poetry; each has distinct forms, units and modes of reception, though genres may blend.
- The functions of literature include entertainment, education, moral guidance and social criticism, cultural preservation, emotional release, language development and mobilisation.
- Oral literature includes folktales, myths, legends, proverbs, riddles, songs, chants, praise poetry, epics and ritual drama; it is characterised by performance, audience participation, communal ownership and formula.
- Written literature offers fixity, named authorship and wide reach; oral and written traditions constantly influence one another.

- Always distinguish the writer from the persona or narrator, and support every critical claim with evidence from the text.

Chapter 2: Prose Fiction: Types, Plot, Setting, Characterisation and Theme

Prose is language as we ordinarily speak and write it, arranged in sentences and paragraphs instead of the lines and stanzas of poetry. **Prose fiction** is invented narrative told in that form. It is the most widely read of the three genres, and in the UTME it is usually the genre on which candidates feel most at ease, because stories are familiar from childhood. Familiarity, however, is not the same as skill. The examination expects you to name the kind of fiction you are reading, to describe how its events are arranged, to say where and when it takes place and why that matters, to explain how people in it are built, and to state what it is really about. This chapter teaches each of those tasks in turn.

Every example in this chapter is an original composition made for teaching. The characters and places are invented, so you can concentrate on the method without confusing it with any published work you may be studying.

2.1 What prose fiction is

Prose fiction is a narrative in prose whose events and characters are, in the main, products of the writer's imagination. The word *fiction* comes from the Latin *fingere*, to shape or form. A fictional story may use real cities, real history and real customs, yet its people and their particular troubles are shaped by the author. A novel set in Lagos in 1975 is still fiction if its heroine, her family and her decisions are invented.

Prose fiction differs from the other genres in several ways. Unlike drama, it does not depend on actors and a stage, so the writer can enter a character's thoughts directly and can cover years in a single sentence. Unlike poetry, it usually does not compress meaning into a few musical lines, so it has room for detailed description, long chains of events and a large cast. Its basic building blocks are **plot**, **setting**, **character** and **theme**, and these are shaped by **narrative technique**, which Chapter 3 treats separately.

2.2 Types of prose fiction

Prose fiction is divided mainly by length and complexity, and then by subject matter.

By length

- **The novel.** A long narrative, usually of more than about 40,000 words, with a developed plot, many characters, and often several lines of action running together. Its length allows the writer to show

change in people across years and to explore a whole community. The word comes from the Italian *novella*, meaning a new thing.

- **The novella (or short novel).** A work between the short story and the novel, perhaps 20,000 to 40,000 words. It keeps a single main line of action like a short story but develops it with more depth.
- **The short story.** A brief narrative that can be read at one sitting. It normally concentrates on one incident, one main character and one effect. Every detail must earn its place, because there is no room to wander.
- **The flash fiction or sketch.** A very short piece, sometimes only a few hundred words, that captures a moment or a single turn of events.

By form and method

- **The epistolary novel** is told through letters, diary entries or messages exchanged by the characters.
- **The picaresque novel** follows a rogue or wanderer through a series of loosely connected adventures, usually exposing the faults of the society he passes through.
- **The bildungsroman** (German for a novel of formation) traces the growth of a young person from childhood towards maturity, showing how experience shapes the mind and character.
- **The historical novel** sets invented characters against the background of real historical events or periods.

- **The detective or crime novel** is built around the solving of a mystery, with clues and false trails.
- **The science fiction novel** imagines scientific or technological change and its effects on people.
- **The romance** centres on love and the obstacles that separate or unite the lovers.
- **The satire** in prose ridicules folly or corruption in order to correct it, as when a story mocks a village council that spends its funds on banquets instead of boreholes.
- **The allegory and the fable.** An allegory is a story whose characters and events stand for ideas, such as greed or justice, in a second hidden meaning. A fable is a short tale, often with animals, ending in a moral lesson.
- **The novel of social realism** pictures ordinary life faithfully, including its poverty, work and politics.

Key point. A single work may belong to several types at once. A story can be a historical novel and also a bildungsroman, if it follows a young person's growth against the background of real events. When asked to classify a work, give the main type and justify it from the text.

2.3 Plot

Plot is the planned arrangement of events in a narrative, with each event connected to the next by cause and effect. The critic E. M. Forster drew the classic distinction: "The king died and then the queen died" is a mere sequence of events, or a *story*; "The king died and then the queen died of grief" is a *plot*, because the second event is explained by the first. Plot answers the question *why* and not merely *what next*.

The stages of a traditional plot

1. **Exposition.** The opening section introduces the main characters, the setting and the situation before trouble begins.
2. **Rising action (complication).** A problem appears, and events grow more tense as the characters struggle. The inciting incident, the event that starts the central conflict, belongs here.
3. **Climax.** The turning point, the moment of greatest tension, when the conflict reaches a peak and the outcome is decided.
4. **Falling action.** The consequences of the climax unfold and the tension eases.
5. **Resolution (denouement).** The loose ends are tied up and the story settles into a new situation. The French word *denouement* means an untying.

Types of plot

- A **linear (chronological) plot** tells events in the order in which they happened.

- A **non-linear plot** rearranges time, using flashback or flash-forward, so that the reader pieces events together.
- A **simple plot** follows one main line of action; a **complex plot** weaves several lines together.
- An **episodic plot** is a chain of separate incidents linked mainly by a central character, as in a picaresque tale.
- A **circular plot** ends where it began, usually with the character or situation changed in meaning.
- A **sub-plot** is a secondary story that runs beside the main plot and often echoes or contrasts with it.
- A **frame story** is a story that encloses another, like a narrator in a compound who tells the tale that makes up the rest of the book.

Conflict

Plot is driven by **conflict**, a struggle between opposing forces. Conflict may be *external*: character against character, against society, against nature, or against fate. It may be *internal*: a character divided between duty and desire. Strong fiction usually combines both, so that the quarrel with another person forces a hidden battle within the self.

Suspense, surprise and the twist

Suspense is the pleasant anxiety of not knowing what will happen, often created by delaying information. **Surprise** is an unexpected event. A **twist** is a sudden change in direction near the end. A writer may also use

a **cliffhanger**, a break at a moment of danger, to carry the reader into the next section.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.1

Read this original outline and identify the plot stages.

Bisi, a young seamstress in Ibadan, borrows ₦80,000 from a cooperative society to buy two sewing machines. Her cousin Tunde persuades her to lend him half the money for a "sure" business in Lagos. He disappears. Bisi hides the loss from her family and takes in night work to keep up repayments, growing exhausted. On the day the cooperative's officials visit her shop, she confesses everything to her mother, who unexpectedly takes her to meet the officials and arranges a longer repayment period. Bisi finishes her contract on time and later helps other young women in the cooperative.

Solution: **Exposition**: Bisi's trade, the loan and the two machines. **Rising action**: Tunde's request, the loss of the money, Bisi's concealment and exhausting night work (the inciting incident is the lending of the money). **Climax**: the visit of the officials and Bisi's confession, the point where the conflict between secrecy and honesty is decided. **Falling action**: the meeting and the new repayment arrangement. **Resolution**: she completes the contract and helps others. The central conflict is internal (shame against honesty) with an external cause (Tunde's betrayal).

2.4 Setting

Setting is the time and place in which a story happens, together with the social and cultural surroundings of its characters. It has four parts: the *physical location* (a village, a flat in Surulere, a motor park), the *historical period*, the *social environment* (customs, class, occupations, beliefs) and the *atmosphere* or mood that these create.

Setting does several jobs in fiction.

- It **creates atmosphere**. A sleepy village in harmattan haze feels different from a roaring Lagos bus terminal at dawn.
- It **shapes character and action**. A fisherman's family lives by the tide; a civil servant's household is ruled by the end of the month.
- It **reflects or contrasts with mood**. A wedding held during a downpour may signal trouble; a quiet funeral in bright sunshine may deepen sorrow by contrast.
- It **supports theme**. A story about greed set in a market, or about corruption set in a ministry, gives the theme a concrete home.
- It can act as a **symbol**, as when a dry, cracked well stands for a community's hopes drying up.
- It can become an **antagonist**, when nature, such as flood or drought, is the force the characters struggle against.

The word **milieu** is sometimes used for the social setting as a whole. **Local colour** means the specific details of dress, food, speech and custom that make a setting vivid and authentic.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.2

Study this original passage and state what the setting contributes.

By four o'clock the bus park at Kuto had gone quiet. The last trader dragged her tarpaulin over the unsold tomatoes, and the sun, red as a coal, slid behind the water tank. Dust hung in the air as though the day itself did not wish to leave. Alhaji Musa's shop, the only one still open, glowed with one tired bulb.

Solution: The **physical setting** is a motor park in the afternoon; the **time** is late day; the **social setting** is a trading community. The details of the covered tomatoes and the single bulb create an atmosphere of weariness and winding down. The image of dust that "did not wish to leave" gives the day a human reluctance and suggests a mood of loneliness or unfinished business, preparing the reader for a quiet but significant event. Setting here therefore sets the mood, supplies local colour and foreshadows what follows.

2.5 Characterisation

Characterisation is the means by which a writer creates and develops the people in a story. A **character** is a person (or sometimes an animal or being) in the narrative. Understanding how writers build characters allows you to describe them accurately and to support every claim with evidence.

Methods of characterisation

- **Direct (explicit) description.** The narrator or another character states the person's qualities: "Mama Ngozi was a stingy woman."
- **Indirect (implicit) presentation.** The reader infers the person from what they *say*, *do*, *think*, *wear*, *where they live* and *how others react to them*.
- **Action.** What people do under pressure reveals more than what they claim.
- **Speech.** Word choice, tone and manner of speaking show education, temper and attitude.
- **Thought.** Access to a character's mind exposes fears and motives that others cannot see.
- **Comment by others.** What neighbours, friends and enemies say about a person adds angles, though these opinions may be biased.
- **Names.** Some writers choose names whose meanings point to character; this is called an *aptronym*.
- **Contrast and foil.** A **foil** is a character who differs sharply from another so as to highlight the latter's qualities, as a generous aunt may throw a miserly uncle into relief.

Types of character

- A **protagonist** is the central character; an **antagonist** opposes the protagonist (it may be a person, a society or a force).
- A **round character** is complex, has many sides and can surprise us; a **flat character** has one or two main traits and is predictable.

- A **dynamic (developing) character** changes in the course of the story; a **static character** remains much the same.
- A **stock character** is a familiar type, such as the wicked stepmother or the boastful soldier.
- A **type** represents a class or group, such as the corrupt politician or the loyal servant.
- A **hero** or **heroine** is a protagonist admired for qualities of courage or goodness; an **anti-hero** lacks conventional heroic qualities and may be weak, ordinary or morally doubtful, yet holds the centre of the story.
- A **confidant** is a character in whom the protagonist confides, giving the writer a way to show private thoughts.

Key point. Never assert a quality without proof. Instead of writing "Tunde is dishonest", write "Tunde is dishonest because he promises a sure profit, takes the money, and then disappears without a word." Evidence converts opinion into analysis.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.3

Analyse the characterisation in this original passage.

Mr Okafor straightened the three pens in his shirt pocket before answering. "The form was due on Monday," he said, without looking up. When the old farmer began to explain about the flooded road, Mr Okafor turned a page and stamped it twice. "Rules," he said, "are not umbrellas. They do not change with the weather." Behind him, a young clerk quietly slid a chair toward the old man.

Solution: Mr Okafor is presented **indirectly**. His fussy handling of the pens suggests rigid neatness; refusing to look up shows coldness; the stamping while the farmer speaks shows indifference and contempt for explanation; his speech, a neat but heartless proverb-like saying, shows pride in strict rule-following. He is a **flat, stock bureaucrat**. The young clerk acts as a **foil**: his small kindness exposes the official's lack of it. The writer thus reveals character through *action, speech and contrast* without once stating directly that Mr Okafor is unkind.

2.6 Theme

Theme is the central idea or insight about life that a work explores. It is not the same as the plot or the subject. The *subject* of a story may be "a harvest dispute between two brothers"; the *theme* may be "greed destroys family bonds" or "pride blinds people to what they owe one

another". A theme is normally expressed as a full statement, not merely a word. "Betrayal" is a topic; "betrayal by those we trust wounds deeper than loss by strangers" is a theme.

Themes arise from the whole work and not from one sentence. A writer rarely states a theme baldly; it emerges from the interaction of plot, character, setting, imagery and tone. A **motif** is a recurring element, such as an image, phrase or object, that supports a theme: a story that returns again and again to broken clocks may be exploring time and loss. A **message** or **moral** is the lesson a work seems to teach, while the theme is the idea it examines.

Common themes in prose fiction

- Love, marriage and family conflict.
- Poverty, wealth and social class.
- Power, corruption and abuse of authority.
- Tradition and modernity; the clash between old and new ways.
- Education and ignorance.
- Identity, belonging and exile.
- Justice and injustice.
- Pride, ambition and downfall.
- War, violence and reconciliation.
- Gender roles and the struggle for equality.
- Death, grief and memory.

How to identify a theme

1. Summarise what happens to the main characters.
2. Ask what the central conflict is about at a deeper level.
3. Note how the main character changes, and what he or she learns or fails to learn.
4. Notice repeated images, symbols and phrases.
5. Examine the ending: who is rewarded or punished, and why?
6. State the idea as a complete sentence and support it with evidence.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.4

State and justify the theme of this original story summary.

Chief Adebayo, the richest man in a small town near Abeokuta, builds a wall around his compound so high that no one can see his mango trees. In the dry season, neighbours go hungry while his fruit rots inside the wall. When a fire breaks out in his house, nobody hears his shouts for help over the wall, and by the time the gate is forced it is too late to save his storehouse.

Solution: The theme is that **selfish isolation brings ruin, because a person who shuts out the community cannot expect its help in need**. Evidence: the wall (a symbol of selfishness) prevents neighbours from sharing the fruit; the rotting fruit shows waste caused by greed; and the wall that keeps help out in the fire becomes the instrument of his loss, a case of poetic justice. Secondary themes are wealth and social responsibility.

2.7 How the elements work together

The four elements of fiction cannot be separated in practice. Plot gives events a shape; setting gives them a world; character gives them human cause and cost; theme gives them meaning. In a well-made story, a change in one element affects the others. If you move a story of ambition from a village to a modern bank, the characters' pressures and the possible plots change as well. A good critical answer therefore links the elements: "The harsh dry-season setting intensifies the conflict between the brothers and so supports the theme of greed."

Examination questions often test these ideas in the form of definitions, matching and identification. You should be able to distinguish, for instance, a flat character from a round one, a sub-plot from the main plot, and a theme from a subject, and to give a short original example of each.

Exercise 2.1

1. A narrative of about 8,000 words that can be read at one sitting and focuses on a single incident is best described as
2. A novel told entirely through letters between characters is called
3. Identify the stage of plot at which the central conflict reaches its highest point.
4. Explain the difference between the story "The farmer died and then his wife died" and the plot "The farmer died and his wife

died of grief."

5. Name three functions of setting in a work of fiction.
6. A character who has only one main quality and does not change is called a _____ character.
7. What is a foil? Give an original example.
8. Which is a theme and which is merely a topic: (a) "corruption"; (b) "corruption destroys public trust in the end"?
9. A story ends with the narrator sitting under the same tree where it began, but now older and sadder. What type of plot structure is this?
10. Explain the term bildungsroman and give one feature of such a novel.
11. In a story, a young man steals food for his sick mother and is then offered a job by the shopkeeper he stole from. Identify the likely theme.

Answers to Exercise 2.1

1. A short story, because it can be read at one sitting and concentrates on a single incident.
2. An epistolary novel (from Greek *epistole*, a letter).
3. The climax.
4. The first is a bare sequence of events in time; the second is a plot because the second event is linked to the first by cause (grief).

5. Any three: creating atmosphere, shaping character and action, reflecting or contrasting with mood, supporting theme, acting as a symbol, acting as an antagonist.
6. Flat (and static).
7. A foil is a character who contrasts with another to highlight that character's qualities, for example a generous trader beside a greedy one, so that the greed shows more clearly.
8. (a) is a topic; (b) is a theme because it is a complete statement of an idea about life.
9. A circular plot.
10. A novel that traces the growth of a young person towards maturity; for example, it shows how experience and mistakes shape the hero's character.
11. Mercy or compassion can overcome the harshness of law or poverty; also poverty driving people to wrongdoing.

Exercise 2.2

1. Read the passage and answer the questions. *Folake counted the notes twice before she handed them over. "It is all there," she said, smiling too widely. But under the counter her left hand held the edge of the table as if the floor might tilt.* (a) What method of characterisation is used? (b) What do the smile and the gripped table suggest?
2. Write one sentence stating a theme that could arise from a story in which two friends, both fishermen, quarrel over a net

and lose the catch of the season.

3. Distinguish between a sub-plot and a frame story.
4. State two ways in which an anti-hero differs from a traditional hero.

Answers to Exercise 2.2

1. (a) Indirect characterisation through action and gesture (and speech). (b) The wide smile and the tight grip suggest hidden nervousness or fear; she may be lying, or fears being found out, since her outward cheerfulness contradicts her bodily tension.
2. For example: Quarrels over small matters can destroy shared prosperity.
3. A sub-plot is a secondary line of action running beside the main plot; a frame story is an outer story that encloses and introduces another tale told within it.
4. An anti-hero lacks conventional qualities of courage or nobility, may be ordinary, weak or morally flawed, and may fail rather than triumph, while a traditional hero is admirable and usually succeeds or dies with honour.

Chapter summary

- Prose fiction is imaginative narrative in prose; its main types by length are the novel, novella, short story and flash fiction,

and by method include epistolary, picaresque, bildungsroman, historical, detective, satire, allegory and fable.

- Plot is a causally connected arrangement of events, normally moving through exposition, rising action, climax, falling action and resolution; it may be linear or non-linear, simple or complex.
- Conflict, internal or external, drives the plot; suspense, surprise, twists and cliffhangers shape the reader's response.
- Setting comprises place, time, social environment and atmosphere; it creates mood, shapes character, supports theme and may act as symbol or antagonist.
- Characters are revealed directly or, more powerfully, indirectly through speech, action, thought, appearance, surroundings and the comments of others.
- Characters may be protagonist or antagonist, round or flat, dynamic or static, stock types, foils or anti-heroes.
- Theme is the central idea explored by the whole work and should be stated as a complete sentence supported by evidence; motifs help to build it.
- Plot, setting, character and theme work together, and good answers show how one supports the other.

Chapter 3: Narrative Technique, Point of View, Style and Language in Prose

Chapter 2 asked *what* a prose story contains: plot, setting, character and theme. This chapter asks *how* the story is told. Two writers can take the same plot, a young man leaves his village for Lagos and returns changed, and produce entirely different books, because they choose different narrators, different orders of events, different kinds of sentences and different attitudes towards the reader. These choices are called **narrative technique** and **style**. Examiners ask about them constantly, usually in the form: *Who is telling the story? What is the effect? What is the tone of the passage? What device is used in the third line?* A candidate who can answer such questions, with evidence from the text, has mastered the most mark-rich part of prose study.

All the passages quoted below are original compositions written for teaching.

3.1 The narrator and point of view

The **narrator** is the voice that tells the story. The narrator is not the same as the author. The author is the real person who wrote the book; the narrator is a role the author creates, and it may be a character inside the story or an invisible voice outside it. **Point of view** (or **narrative**

perspective) is the position from which the story is told: how much the narrator knows, how close the narrator stands to the events, and whose mind the reader is allowed to enter.

First-person point of view

The narrator is a character who says "I" and "we". Everything is seen through that person's eyes.

- **Advantages:** it creates intimacy and a sense of truth, since the reader hears an eyewitness; it allows the reader to experience the narrator's feelings directly; it can reveal character through the way the narrator speaks.
- **Limitations:** the narrator can report only what he or she sees, hears or learns; the narrator may be biased, mistaken or dishonest.

A first-person narrator who cannot be fully trusted is called an **unreliable narrator**. The reader gradually senses a gap between what the narrator says and what the facts show. A boastful narrator who claims everyone admired him while the details show people avoiding him is unreliable. A narrator may also be a **witness narrator**, a minor character who observes the hero and tells his story, or a **protagonist narrator**, who tells his own story.

Third-person omniscient point of view

The narrator stands outside the story and uses "he", "she" and "they". An **omniscient** (all-knowing) narrator knows the past, present and future of every character, can enter any mind, can describe events happening in

different places at once, and may comment on the meaning of events.

- **Advantages:** wide scope, many characters and a full social picture; the writer can use dramatic irony by letting the reader know what a character does not.
- **Limitations:** it can seem distant, and an intrusive narrator can lecture the reader.

Third-person limited point of view

The narrator uses "he" or "she" but sees and knows only what one character (or a small number of characters) sees and knows. The reader follows that character closely, as in the first person, but the writer keeps the freedom to describe the character from outside.

Other perspectives

- **Second person.** The narrator addresses "you" as though the reader were the character. It is rare and creates a striking, sometimes accusing effect.
- **Objective (or dramatic) point of view.** The narrator reports only what can be seen and heard, like a camera, and never enters anyone's thoughts. The reader must infer feelings from action and speech.
- **Multiple points of view.** Different chapters or sections are told by different narrators, so the reader sees one event from several angles.
- **Stream of consciousness.** The narrator records the unbroken flow of a character's thoughts and impressions, often without regular

punctuation or order. It belongs mainly to twentieth-century modernist writing.

- **Epistolary form.** The narrative is told through letters or diary entries.

Key point. To identify point of view, ask three questions: (1) Which pronouns does the narrator use for the main events? (2) Whose thoughts do we hear? (3) Does the narrator know more than any single character could? "I" with only one mind visible means first person; "he/she" with access to many minds means omniscient; "he/she" with access to one mind means limited.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.1

Identify the point of view of each original passage and give one reason.

(a) *I counted the coins twice because my hands were shaking. If Mama saw that I had spent the market money on the football match, she would not shout; she would simply stop speaking to me, and that was worse.*

(b) *Kemi counted the coins twice because her hands were shaking. She did not know that, in the next room, her mother had already found the empty tin and was deciding, with sorrow rather than anger, to say nothing.*

(c) *Kemi counted the coins twice. Her hands trembled. Behind the curtain, a tin lid clinked once against the table, and the radio was switched off.*

Solution: (a) **First person**: the pronouns "I" and "my", and the inner fear is known only to the speaker. (b) **Third-person omniscient**: the narrator reports Kemi's feelings and also what the mother thinks in another room, something Kemi cannot know. (c) **Objective (dramatic)**: the narrator records only visible and audible facts (trembling, a clinking lid, a radio switched off) and does not enter any mind; the reader must infer the mother's reaction.

3.2 Techniques for handling time and information

Flashback (analepsis)

A **flashback** interrupts the present action to show an earlier event. It explains why a character behaves as he does or supplies information the reader needs. A story that opens with an old trader sitting silently at his burnt shop and then returns twenty years to the day he first opened it is using flashback.

Flash-forward (prolepsis) and foreshadowing

A **flash-forward** jumps into the future. **Foreshadowing** is subtler: it plants hints of what will happen, such as a cracked mirror before a death, a storm gathering before a quarrel, or an ominous remark that seems casual. It builds suspense and makes the later event feel prepared rather than accidental.

In medias res

The Latin phrase means "in the middle of things". The story begins at an exciting point in the action, and earlier events are filled in afterwards. Many adventure stories and epics open this way.

Summary and scene

A narrator can **summarise** events ("Three harvests passed") or dramatise them as a **scene** with detailed action and dialogue. Summary speeds the story and covers long periods; scene slows it and gives importance to a moment. Skilled writers use summary for the unimportant and scene for the decisive.

Stories within stories

A **frame narrative** encloses one tale within another. A **digression** is a deliberate departure from the main line, such as an elder's folktale told in the middle of a quarrel, usually to comment on the main action. In African fiction such inserted tales, proverbs and songs often carry the community's wisdom.

Suspense, withholding and delay

Writers control what the reader knows. They may delay information, give clues that mislead (**red herrings** in detective fiction), or leave the ending open. The order of telling, rather than the order of events, creates the effect. The events in **chronological** order form the *story*; the order in which the narrator presents them forms the *plot* as told.

3.3 Style

Style is the characteristic way a writer uses language: the choice of words, the shape of sentences, the figures of speech, the rhythm and the tone. Style is not decoration added to content; it is part of the meaning.

A plain, clipped style may suggest harsh reality, while a rich, musical style may suggest celebration or nostalgia.

Diction

Diction is the writer's choice of words. Examine whether the words are:

- **Simple or complex**: short, common words or learned, Latinate ones;
- **Concrete or abstract**: words for things we can see and touch, or for ideas such as "honour" and "justice";
- **Formal or informal**: standard formal English, colloquial speech or slang;
- **Connotative or denotative**: *denotation* is the dictionary meaning; *connotation* is the feeling or association a word carries. "Home" and "residence" denote the same place but connote different warmth;
- **Archaic or modern**: old-fashioned words or current usage.

Syntax

Syntax is the arrangement of words into sentences. Short sentences give speed, tension and a feeling of bluntness. Long, flowing sentences with many clauses give a reflective, leisurely or overwhelming effect. A sentence that delays its main point to the end is a **periodic sentence**; one that states the main point first and then adds details is a **loose sentence**. A sentence pattern repeated in a series (**parallelism**) creates rhythm and emphasis. Inversion (placing words out of normal order) draws attention to the displaced word.

Tone and mood

Tone is the writer's or narrator's attitude towards the subject and the reader: ironic, sympathetic, scornful, humorous, solemn, detached, bitter, tender and so on. **Mood** (or atmosphere) is the feeling the passage creates in the reader: gloomy, tense, peaceful, festive. Tone belongs to the voice; mood belongs to the reader's response. They often coincide but need not: a narrator may describe a funeral in a light, mocking tone while the reader still feels sadness.

Register

Register is the variety of language suited to a situation or profession: legal, medical, religious, market-place. A writer who puts courtroom language into a market quarrel produces comedy through the clash of registers.

Sentence length and paragraphing

Notice also the rhythm created by paragraph length, one-line paragraphs for shock, and the use of dialogue versus description. These are style choices a good answer can point to.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.2

Comment on the style and tone of this original passage.

The Honourable Commissioner arrived at the primary school two hours late, in three cars. He spoke for fifty minutes about the sacred duty of education, then departed before the children's song, which, the headmistress noted, was about punctuality.

Solution: The **diction** is formal and slightly inflated ("Honourable", "sacred duty"), which the facts then undermine. The **syntax** consists of controlled, balanced sentences, with the detail that gives the joke delayed to the end of each ("in three cars", "was about punctuality"), which is the pattern of a periodic sentence. The **tone** is **ironic and satirical**: the narrator pretends to respect the official while exposing his hypocrisy; the contrast between his speech about duty and his lateness is the source of the humour. The **mood** for the reader is amused disapproval.

3.4 Language in African prose

African writers in English face a special question: how to express African experience in a language that came with colonial rule. They answer in several ways, and recognising these answers earns marks in the examination.

- **Proverbs.** Proverbs are the "palm-oil with which words are eaten" in many African societies, a well-known idea in Igbo thought. They

compress wisdom, add authority to an elder's speech and mark rhetorical skill. Their use in a novel helps characterise speakers and convey cultural values.

- **Translation and transliteration.** Phrases from a local language are rendered closely into English, keeping their sentence pattern and imagery, so that the English carries the rhythm of the original.
- **Code-switching and code-mixing.** Characters move between English and an indigenous language or Pidgin. Direct use of local words (names of foods, titles, greetings) preserves local colour.
- **Nigerian Pidgin.** It marks social class, humour, intimacy and the voice of the street. In fiction it often gives authenticity to market traders, soldiers and young urban characters.
- **Songs, chants, folktales and praise names.** These bring oral tradition into the written text.
- **Varied registers of English.** Educated characters may speak formal English, while less schooled characters use simpler or localised forms, so that language signals class and education.

A famous debate concerns whether African writers should write in European languages at all. Some, such as Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, argued strongly for writing in African languages and changed his own practice by writing in Gikuyu; others, such as Chinua Achebe, defended the use of English adapted to African experience, speaking of an English that can carry the weight of the writer's African experience yet remain in full communion with its ancestral home. You should be able to state both positions in general terms.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.3

Identify the language features in this original passage.

"A child who refuses to listen to the drum," the old man said slowly, "will dance on the wrong day." He spat on the ground, tapped his staff twice, and added, "Wetin you wan make I tell you? The thing don pass talk."

Solution: The first speech is a **proverb** using the image of the drum and dance, which advises obedience to guidance; it gives the elder authority and shows the culture's reliance on oral wisdom. The second speech is in **Nigerian Pidgin**, showing **code-switching** from formal English to Pidgin. The switch signals a move from ceremonial advice to blunt intimacy and may suggest the old man's frustration. The gestures (spitting, tapping the staff) add **local colour** and characterise him as a traditional elder.

3.5 Other narrative devices

Irony

Irony exists when there is a contrast between appearance and reality. The main kinds are:

- **Verbal irony**: saying the opposite of what is meant ("What a punctual man," of someone who arrives at noon for an eight o'clock meeting);

- **Situational irony**: the outcome is the opposite of what is expected (a fire station burns down);
- **Dramatic irony**: the reader knows something that a character does not, so the character's words and actions carry a meaning he cannot see.

Satire, parody and humour

Satire mocks human weakness or social evil in order to correct it, as in a story that ridicules corrupt contractors. **Parody** imitates a serious work or style for comic effect. Humour may be gentle (**comedy of manners**) or sharp (**sarcasm**).

Symbolism, allegory and imagery

A **symbol** is a person, object or event that stands for something larger: a broken calabash for a broken marriage. **Allegory** extends this into a whole story in which characters and events stand for abstract ideas. **Imagery** is language that appeals to the senses. These are examined in detail in Chapter 8.

Suspense, climax and anti-climax

An **anti-climax** is a sudden fall from an important matter to a trivial one, used for comic or ironic effect. A **cliffhanger** ends a section at the moment of greatest tension.

Realism, naturalism and magic realism

Realism presents life as it ordinarily seems to be. **Naturalism** goes further, showing people as shaped by heredity and environment, often in poverty. **Magic realism** mixes realistic narration with elements of the supernatural treated as ordinary. Some African and Latin American novels combine spirit-world and daily life in this way, which suits traditions in which the ancestors and the living share one world.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.4

Read the original passage and name the techniques used.

Segun polished his shoes until he could see the whole of his ambition in them. In the interview room, he told the panel that he was punctual, thorough and incorruptible. Outside, in the corridor, a cleaner wiped a puddle from the floor, and Segun, hurrying to leave, slipped in it and landed sitting in front of the Permanent Secretary.

Solution: **Metaphorical language** in "see the whole of his ambition in them" is a hyperbole combined with imagery. The boasting about his qualities followed by the slip is **situational irony**, ending in an **anti-climax**: the dignified scene collapses into a pratfall. The tone is gently comic and satirical about self-importance. The writer also uses **summary** (the interview in one sentence) and **scene** (the fall).

3.6 Writing about technique in the examination

A good answer on narrative technique follows a pattern: **name** the technique, **quote or point to** the evidence, and **explain the effect**. Compare these two sentences about the passage in Example 3.4.

- Weak: "The writer uses irony."
- Strong: "The writer uses situational irony: Segun claims to be punctual and incorruptible, yet his hurry and fall in front of the Permanent Secretary expose his vanity, so the reader laughs at him while feeling a little sympathy."

Never list devices without naming their effect. The question "What is the effect?" is the single most common follow-up in the paper.

> **Key point.** Style questions have a standard checklist: diction, syntax, imagery, tone, point of view, and use of oral material. Run through it quickly on any passage before answering.

Exercise 3.1

1. Distinguish between an author and a narrator.
2. A story told by a villager who watches the hero's rise and fall but is not himself the hero uses which type of narrator?
3. State two advantages and one limitation of the first-person point of view.

4. Define *in medias res* and name one effect of beginning a story that way.
5. What is the difference between tone and mood?
6. A narrator reports, "Ngozi smiled, though in her heart she had already decided to leave." Which point of view is this, and why?
7. Name three ways in which African writers in English adapt the language to African experience.
8. Explain the difference between dramatic irony and situational irony with an example of each.
9. What is a periodic sentence? Why might a writer use one for humour?
10. What is the difference between foreshadowing and flashback?
11. Which technique is used when a narrator says "Three dry seasons passed before the well was dug"? Say what effect it has on pace.
12. Explain what is meant by an unreliable narrator and say how a reader detects one.

Answers to Exercise 3.1

1. The author is the real person who writes the book; the narrator is the voice or role the author creates to tell the story, which may differ from the author in character, opinions and knowledge.

2. A witness (or observer) narrator, speaking in the first person but not the protagonist.
3. Advantages: intimacy and authenticity; direct access to one mind's feelings. Limitation: the narrator knows only what he or she sees or learns and may be biased.
4. *In medias res* means beginning in the middle of the action; it grabs attention at once and creates curiosity, with earlier events supplied later by flashback.
5. Tone is the narrator's attitude to subject and reader; mood is the atmosphere or feeling the passage produces in the reader.
6. Third-person omniscient (or at least third-person with access to thought), because the narrator uses "she" and reveals her private decision.
7. Any three of: proverbs; translation of local idiom; code-switching; Pidgin; indigenous words and names; songs and folktales.
8. Dramatic irony: the reader knows something the character does not (the audience knows the villain waits behind the door as the hero enters happily). Situational irony: the outcome is opposite to expectation (a thief's own house is robbed on the day he is praised for honesty).
9. A sentence whose main point is held back until the end; it builds expectation and lets the surprise or joke land at the close.
10. Foreshadowing hints at later events; flashback returns to events that happened earlier than the present action.
11. Summary; it speeds the pace and covers a long time in a few words.
12. An unreliable narrator is one whose account cannot be fully trusted because of bias, ignorance or dishonesty; the reader detects this

when the narrator's claims conflict with the facts, with other characters' behaviour or with the narrator's own revealed actions.

Exercise 3.2

Read this original passage and answer the questions below it.

When the generator coughed and died, the whole street breathed out. We had been holding our breath since evening, as though silence itself might frighten the darkness away. Mama Lekan lit her lantern and set it in the window like a small, tired moon. "Light is light," she announced to nobody, "even if it is only enough to see the next problem."

1. Identify the point of view and give evidence.
2. Find one simile or metaphor and state what it suggests.
3. Describe the tone of Mama Lekan's remark.
4. What mood does the first sentence help create?

Answers to Exercise 3.2

1. First-person plural (a community "we"): "We had been holding our breath"; the narrator is part of the street.
2. "like a small, tired moon": a simile suggesting a gentle but weak light and a weary, patient resident; also "the whole street breathed out", a personification of the community.

3. Wry, humorous and philosophical: she makes light of hardship and accepts it with resigned good humour.
4. A mood of tense waiting followed by relief, mixed with resignation, as the community reacts together to the power failure.

Chapter summary

- The narrator is the voice that tells the story and is distinct from the author; point of view may be first person, third-person omniscient, third-person limited, second person, objective or multiple.
- Narrators may be reliable or unreliable; the choice of narrator controls what the reader knows and how far the reader trusts the account.
- Time and information are handled through flashback, flash-forward, foreshadowing, in medias res, summary and scene, frame stories, digressions and delay of information.
- Style is the writer's characteristic use of language: diction, syntax, tone, mood and register; tone belongs to the writer's attitude, mood to the reader's response.
- African prose in English often uses proverbs, translation of local idiom, code-switching, Pidgin, songs and folktales, and the debate over language choice is part of the literary background.

- Important devices include irony (verbal, situational, dramatic), satire, parody, symbolism, allegory, anti-climax and cliffhanger; realism, naturalism and magic realism describe broad modes of representing life.
- In the examination, name the technique, give evidence and state the effect.

Chapter 4: Drama: Types, Elements and Dramatic Techniques

Prose is written to be read silently by one person at a time. Drama is different in kind. A play is written to be performed by living actors before a living audience, and its full meaning appears only when words, voices, bodies, light, costume and silence work together on a stage. For this reason the study of drama requires a double vision. The candidate must read the printed text carefully, as with any book, and must also imagine the performance, asking how a line would be spoken, where an actor would stand, what the audience would see at the moment the words are uttered. The examiner expects both skills: knowledge of the types and elements of drama, and the ability to say what a particular technique achieves in a particular scene.

This chapter defines drama, distinguishes its major types, explains the elements of a play, describes the technical devices that dramatists use, and shows how to answer questions on a drama text. All passages and scenes quoted or described below are original compositions made for teaching.

4.1 What drama is

The word *drama* comes from a Greek word meaning "to do" or "to act". A **drama** is a story told through action and dialogue by performers who impersonate characters. A **play** is the written or performed work; a **playwright** or **dramatist** is its author; the **script** or **text** is the written form, containing the speeches and the instructions for staging. The place of performance may be a theatre, a school hall, a village square, a radio studio or a television set.

Four features distinguish drama from the other genres.

- **Dialogue is the main vehicle.** In a novel the narrator can describe a character's thoughts at length. In a play the audience learns what people think chiefly from what they say to one another and what they do.
- **Performance is part of the work.** The play exists fully only in performance. The same text may be staged in many ways, and a director's choices contribute to its meaning.
- **A live audience is present.** The response of the audience, its laughter, silence and tension, is part of the event. Playwrights design scenes to produce such responses.
- **Compression.** A play must make its point within a limited time, usually two or three hours, and within the limits of the stage. It therefore selects only the most significant moments and states them with great economy.

Key point. Drama is "literature in action". When the examination asks about a play, always consider both the words on the page and the effect that those words would have on an audience in the theatre.

4.2 Types of drama

Plays are classified mainly by the kind of story they tell and the feeling they leave with the audience. The principal types are tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce, historical drama and the problem play, with folk opera as a further form.

Tragedy

A **tragedy** is a serious play in which a central character, usually of high standing and admirable qualities, suffers a disaster that often ends in death. The disaster typically arises from the character's own flaw or error, combined with circumstances beyond control. The Greek philosopher Aristotle, writing about ancient Greek drama, said that tragedy arouses pity and fear in the audience and brings about **catharsis**, a purging or release of those emotions, so that the audience leaves the theatre emotionally cleansed.

Several terms belong to the study of tragedy:

- **Tragic hero:** the great but flawed central figure whose fall is the subject of the play.

- **Hamartia (tragic flaw):** the weakness or error of judgement that leads to the hero's downfall, such as pride, jealousy, rashness or blind ambition.
- **Hubris:** excessive pride or overconfidence, a common form of tragic flaw.
- **Peripeteia (reversal):** the sudden turn of fortune from prosperity to suffering.
- **Anagnorisis (recognition):** the moment at which the hero realises the truth about himself or his situation.
- **Catharsis:** the emotional release felt by the audience at the end.

Imagine an original play, *The Last Drum of Ogbomoso*, whose hero is a famous chief and master drummer. He is so confident of his skill that he ignores the elders' warning and plays at a forbidden hour, and the ensuing calamity destroys his family. His pride is the hamartia; the sudden loss of his name and home is the reversal; the night on which he admits his folly is the recognition; and the audience's grief and pity, followed by a sense of calm, is the catharsis.

Comedy

A **comedy** is a play that amuses the audience and ends happily, usually with the solving of a problem, the reconciliation of enemies or a wedding. Its characters are ordinary people and its subject is the follies of everyday life. Comedy has several varieties:

- **Romantic comedy** follows lovers who overcome obstacles to be united.

- **Comedy of manners** laughs at the behaviour, fashions and pretensions of a particular social class.
- **Comedy of humours** or **comedy of character** exposes the ridiculous obsession of a single type, such as the miser or the braggart.
- **Satiric comedy** uses laughter to attack vice, corruption and hypocrisy.

Tragicomedy

Tragicomedy mixes tragic and comic elements. A serious story may be relieved by humour, or a comic story may turn briefly dark, or a play may move towards disaster and then be rescued by a fortunate reversal. A good deal of modern drama is tragicomic, since real life itself does not separate laughter from sorrow.

Farce

A **farce** is broad comedy that depends on absurd situations, mistaken identity, rapid action, slapstick and exaggeration. Its aim is laughter, not reflection. A scene in which a husband hides a stranger in a wardrobe, and everyone who enters the room mistakes the wrong person for the right one, would be farcical.

Other types

- **Historical drama** dramatises real events and persons of the past, often to examine their meaning for the present.

- **Problem play** (or **drama of ideas**) presents a social or moral problem, such as corruption, the position of women or the clash between tradition and modernity, and invites the audience to think about it.
- **Folk opera** is a Nigerian form that combines spoken drama, song, music and dance, drawing on traditional performance; the Yoruba travelling theatre is its best-known tradition.
- **Theatre of the absurd** is a twentieth-century type in which illogical situations and broken speech express the view that human life lacks clear purpose.

4.3 The structure of a play

Most plays are divided into **acts**, and acts into **scenes**. An act is a major division, often marked by a lowering of the curtain or a change of lighting; a scene is a smaller unit usually set in one place and time. A very short play may have only one act. A scene changes when the place, time or group of characters changes.

The plot of a play follows the same logic as the plot of a novel (Chapter 2) but is tighter. Critics speak of the following movements.

1. **Exposition** introduces the characters, the setting and the situation. A good dramatist hides it inside natural conversation, as when two servants gossip about the master's quarrel with his brother.
2. **Rising action** develops the conflict through a chain of complications.

3. **Climax** (or crisis) is the turning point, the moment of greatest tension at which the conflict reaches its peak and the direction of the story is decided.
4. **Falling action** (or **resolution**) shows the consequences of the climax.
5. **Denouement** (or **catastrophe** in tragedy) is the final unravelling, in which the outcome is made clear.

Conflict is the engine of drama. It may be between persons (a father and his son), between a person and society (a young teacher and a corrupt council), between a person and fate or the gods, or within a person's mind (duty against desire). Without conflict a play has nothing to resolve.

4.4 The elements of drama

Plot

The plot is the arrangement of events. In drama the plot is often classified as **simple** (one main line of action) or **complex** (with a sub-plot). A **sub-plot** is a secondary story that runs beside the main one and often comments on it, offers comic relief or sharpens the theme.

Characters

Characters are revealed in drama by what they say, what they do, what others say about them, and how they respond under pressure. The **protagonist** is the central figure; the **antagonist** opposes the

protagonist; a **foil** is a character who, by contrast, throws the qualities of another into relief. A **confidant** is a trusted friend to whom a character confides secrets, which allows the audience to hear the character's thoughts without a soliloquy. The **chorus**, a group of speakers who comment on the action, is used in Greek tragedy and in many African plays that draw on communal performance. A **stock character** is a stereotype such as the braggart, the miser or the foolish servant. A **round character** shows several sides and may change; a **flat character** is a single quality.

Setting

The setting is the time and place of the action, the social environment, and the physical arrangement of the stage. Stage setting, or **scenery**, may be realistic (a detailed sitting room) or symbolic (a bare platform with a single tree). Setting also establishes atmosphere and often contributes to the theme.

Theme

The theme is the central idea explored. Drama tends to state its theme in strong contrasts: loyalty against betrayal, tradition against change, ambition against conscience, justice against power. A candidate should state the theme as a complete idea, for example "the play shows that ambition without conscience destroys the ambitious", not as a single word.

Language and style

Dramatic language includes ordinary dialogue, **verse** (lines with a regular rhythm, used in Shakespeare's plays and in much classical drama), and **prose**. Playwrights adjust the language to the character: elders may speak in proverbs, a clerk in careful official English, a trader in Pidgin. Such differences of **register** reveal social class, education and mood.

Spectacle, music and dance

Costume, make-up, lighting, props, music, song, dance and mime make up what Aristotle called **spectacle**. In African drama these elements are especially important, for song, drumming and dance often carry meaning as fully as speech does.

4.5 Dramatic techniques and devices

Soliloquy, monologue and aside

A **soliloquy** is a speech in which a character, alone on stage, speaks his or her thoughts aloud. It is a convention that gives the audience direct access to the character's mind, doubts and plans. A **monologue** is a long speech by one character to other characters or to the audience. An **aside** is a brief remark made by a character that the audience hears but the other characters on stage are supposed not to hear. Imagine a scene in which a councillor smiles at a visitor and says warmly, "You are always

welcome in my house." Turning from the visitor, he mutters, "And always expensive." The mutter is an aside; it exposes his greed and creates comedy by contrast with his public warmth.

Dramatic irony

Dramatic irony occurs when the audience knows something that a character does not. If the audience has seen the chief's enemy poison the cup, and the chief then raises it with a toast to friendship, every line he speaks carries a double meaning. It produces suspense, pity and sometimes bitter comedy.

Suspense and surprise

Suspense is the audience's anxious expectation about what will happen; **surprise** is a sudden unexpected event. Skilful dramatists use suspense more often, because an audience that knows danger approaches watches with greater tension. **Foreshadowing** hints in advance at later events, for example an early mention of a cracked bridge that will later collapse.

Comic relief

Comic relief is a humorous episode placed in a serious play to ease the tension. It also may sharpen the seriousness around it, for example the gatekeeper's joking about his lost sandal just before the king is murdered.

Flashback and the play within a play

A **flashback** shows earlier events, usually through a change of lighting or a speech that recalls them. A **play within a play** is a performance staged by characters inside the main action, often used to expose a character's guilt or to comment on the main theme.

Stage directions, props and symbols

Stage directions are the writer's instructions about movement, tone, setting and effects, usually printed in italics or brackets. They guide actors and give the reader information that is normally conveyed visually. **Props** (properties) are movable objects used in the action: a stool, a staff, a calabash. A prop may become a **symbol**: the broken calabash that recurs through a play can stand for a broken marriage and a broken community.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.1

Read this original scene. *Mama Kemi, a market woman, is counting money behind her stall. Her nephew Dayo enters, nervous. MAMA KEMI (without looking up): "You have come at the hour when thieves and relatives arrive." DAYO: "Aunty, I came only to greet you." MAMA KEMI: "Greetings, then. Now say how much you want." (Dayo is silent. A bell tolls offstage.)* Identify two techniques and state their effects.

Solution: First, the line "the hour when thieves and relatives arrive" is irony and wit: Mama Kemi equates relatives with thieves, which characterises her as shrewd and suspicious and creates humour. Second, the silence of Dayo followed by the bell is a dramatic pause with sound effect: it suggests that his guilt or embarrassment is real and builds tension. Both techniques reveal character without any narration, which is the essence of drama.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.2

Identify the type of play: a young farmer wins the heart of a chief's daughter by outwitting a miserly suitor; the play is full of songs, mistaken identities and a surprise discovery, and ends with a wedding feast.

Solution: The play is a **romantic comedy**, with farcical elements. The lovers overcome obstacles (the miser), the mood is light, the plot turns on mistaken identity, and the ending is a happy resolution marked by a wedding. Songs are a feature of folk performance.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.3

A play's hero, a governor named Adebisi, is warned by his wife that his friend is plotting against him. He refuses to listen, saying no man could betray him. In Act 4 the friend overthrows him, and in a final speech Adebisi admits his foolish trust. Name the tragic flaw, the reversal and the recognition.

Solution: The flaw (hamartia) is excessive pride and blind trust, shown in his refusal to heed his wife. The reversal (peripeteia) is the overthrow in Act 4, which turns his fortune from power to ruin. The recognition (anagnorisis) is the final speech in which he admits his folly. His fall is likely to arouse pity because his error is human, and fear because the same mistake could be ours.

4.6 Drama in Africa and Nigeria

African drama has deep roots in ritual, festival, masquerade, storytelling and dance. Performances at harvests, funerals, initiations and the installation of rulers combined mask, music and communal participation long before the written play appeared. The Yoruba *Egungun* masquerade, the Igbo *Mmanwu* and the Hausa *Wasan Kwaikwayo* are examples of performance traditions that dramatists have drawn upon. The travelling theatre of Yorubaland, led by artists such as Hubert Ogunde in the 1940s, brought song, dance and satire to popular audiences, and its folk operas were often performed in Yoruba.

Written drama in English developed in the twentieth century, mixing European forms with proverbs, praise-songs, chorus, ritual and dance, and treating tradition and change, colonialism and corruption. Authors and texts are discussed in Chapters 7 and 8.

4.7 Shakespeare and the English dramatic tradition

A good deal of the non-African drama set for examination belongs to the English tradition, of which William Shakespeare (1564 to 1616) is the central figure. His plays are divided into comedies, histories, tragedies and romances. A knowledge of the following conventions helps with any Elizabethan or Jacobean play.

- **Verse and prose.** Shakespeare often used **blank verse**, unrhymed lines of ten syllables with five stresses (iambic pentameter), for

noble characters and serious moments, and prose for comic characters, letters and madness. A change from verse to prose may therefore signal a change of mood or class.

- **Rhyming couplets** often close a scene, giving a sense of finality.
- **Soliloquy** is used at crucial points for the revelation of the hero's mind.
- **The five-act structure** corresponds roughly to exposition, rising action, climax, falling action and catastrophe.
- **The Elizabethan stage** had no elaborate scenery, so setting is often established in the dialogue itself.
- **Comic relief** and sub-plots are usual even in tragedy.

The ideas described in this chapter apply equally to a classical play, a Shakespearean tragedy, a modern English drama and a Nigerian folk opera.

4.8 How to answer questions on a drama text

1. **Know the plot in order.** Be able to summarise each act in two or three sentences, with the climax identified.
2. **Know each major character by quality, action and evidence.** For every character, remember two traits and a scene that proves each trait.
3. **Link each theme to specific incidents.** "Corruption" earns little; "corruption is shown when the chairman takes a bribe in Act 2" earns marks.

4. **Name the technique, quote or refer to the moment, and state the effect.**
5. **Remember the stage.** Mention staging effects (lighting, silence, music, movement) when they apply.
6. **Do not retell the story.** Examiners reward analysis, not summary.

Key point. In a question on the opening of a play, state what the exposition tells us about character, conflict and setting. In a question on the end of a play, state how the resolution completes the theme and what the audience feels.

Exercise 4.1

1. Define drama and give two features that distinguish it from prose fiction.
2. Explain the terms hamartia, peripeteia and catharsis.
3. A play shows a king whose pride leads to his death, and the audience feels pity and fear. What type of play is this?
4. What is the difference between a soliloquy and a monologue?
5. A character, in company, quietly tells the audience that he is lying to the others. What device is this?
6. Give the order of the movements of a play, from exposition to denouement.
7. What is the effect of dramatic irony? Give an original example.

8. Explain comic relief and state why a dramatist might use it in a tragedy.
9. What is a sub-plot, and what two purposes can it serve?
10. Name three features that African drama commonly borrows from oral performance.
11. What is the difference between farce and comedy of manners?
12. Why is the stage direction "(She lowers the broken calabash slowly and does not speak.)" important in performance?

Answers to Exercise 4.1

1. Drama is a story told through action and dialogue by performers before an audience. It relies on dialogue and performance, and it is compressed for the stage, unlike prose, which may use extended narration and description.
2. Hamartia is the tragic flaw or error of the hero; peripeteia is the reversal of fortune; catharsis is the emotional purging felt by the audience.
3. Tragedy, because it shows a great person's fall from his own flaw and arouses pity and fear.
4. A soliloquy is a speech spoken by a character alone, revealing thoughts; a monologue is a long speech to other characters or the audience.
5. An aside.
6. Exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, denouement.

7. It produces suspense, irony and pity because the audience knows more than the character; for example, the audience knows the cup is poisoned but the chief toasts with it.
8. Comic relief is humour inside a serious play; it eases tension and can also make the serious moments more striking by contrast.
9. A subordinate story beside the main plot; it can give comic relief and reinforce or contrast with the theme.
10. Any three of song, dance, drumming, chorus, proverbs, storytelling, audience participation, masquerade and ritual.
11. Farce depends on absurd situations and physical comedy for laughter; comedy of manners satirises the behaviour of a social class through wit and dialogue.
12. It communicates by action and silence, suggests the symbolic loss of a marriage or community, and shows that some meanings need no words.

Exercise 4.2

1. Read: *(Evening. Chief Okoro sits alone beside a lamp.) OKORO: "They call me father of the town, yet not one of them has come to my door since the rains began. Is this how a lion is honoured when his teeth fall out?"* Name the device and the effect.
2. In a play, the audience sees a servant hide a letter, but the master walks in and asks for it politely and trustingly. What kind of irony is present?

3. Why might a dramatist write a nobleman's speeches in verse and a gatekeeper's in prose?
4. State two ways in which a prop may contribute to meaning.
5. What is the dramatic purpose of an exposition that is concealed inside a conversation between two servants?
6. In a tragedy, the hero says in the last act, "I see now that my own pride was the thief." Which element of tragedy is this?
7. Give two reasons why a play may have a chorus.

Answers to Exercise 4.2

1. Soliloquy, together with metaphor (the lion with fallen teeth); it reveals his loneliness and wounded pride.
2. Dramatic irony, because the audience knows what the master does not.
3. To mark rank and mood; verse suggests dignity, while prose suggests everyday or comic speech.
4. It can be a symbol (such as a broken calabash for a broken marriage), and it can advance the action or reveal character through how it is handled.
5. It gives the audience necessary background naturally, without interrupting the action.
6. Anagnorisis (recognition), where the hero perceives the cause of his fall.

7. The chorus comments on the action and voices the opinion of the community; it also offers song, dance and background information.

Chapter summary

- Drama is a story told through dialogue and action for performance before an audience; it should be studied as both text and performance.
- The main types are tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy and farce, with historical drama, problem plays, satire, folk opera and absurd drama as further forms.
- Tragedy involves a flawed hero (hamartia), reversal (peripeteia), recognition (anagnorisis) and catharsis.
- A play is organised in acts and scenes and moves from exposition through rising action and climax to falling action and denouement; conflict drives it.
- The elements of drama are plot, character, setting, theme, language and spectacle.
- Dramatic techniques include soliloquy, monologue, aside, dramatic irony, suspense, foreshadowing, comic relief, flashback, play within a play, stage directions, props and symbols.
- African drama draws on ritual, masquerade, song, dance, proverbs and communal performance; Shakespearean drama uses blank verse, soliloquy and five-act structure.

- In the examination, name the technique, refer to the moment, and state its effect on character, theme or audience.

Chapter 5: Poetry: Forms, Types, Structure and Sound

Poetry is the most concentrated of the three genres. A novelist may take two hundred pages to create a mood; a poet may do it in fourteen lines. This concentration is the reason poetry is both rewarding and difficult. Every word has been chosen for its meaning, its sound and its suggestion; every line break, every pause and every repeated sound is a decision. A candidate who learns to read poetry slowly, noticing how it is built as well as what it says, gains marks in the set-text paper and in the unseen-poem question alike.

This chapter defines poetry, describes its types and forms, explains stanza, rhyme, rhythm and metre, and shows how to scan a line. Figures of speech and imagery are treated separately in Chapter 6. All poems quoted below are original compositions written for teaching.

5.1 What poetry is

Poetry is a form of literature that expresses feeling, experience and thought in carefully patterned, compressed language, usually arranged in **lines** and **stanzas**. The person who writes it is the **poet**; the speaker who utters the poem is the **persona** or **poetic voice**. The persona is not always the poet. A poet may speak as an old widow, a soldier or a river, and the candidate must always ask: *who is speaking, to whom, and in what situation?*

Poetry differs from prose in several ways.

- **Arrangement.** Poetry is arranged in lines, which end where the poet chooses and not where the page ends. Prose runs in paragraphs.
- **Compression.** Poetry says much in few words and relies on suggestion; prose explains.
- **Sound.** Rhythm, rhyme, alliteration and other sound effects matter greatly in poetry, since poems are meant to be heard.
- **Figurative language.** Poetry relies heavily on imagery and metaphor.

A poem need not rhyme. **Free verse** has neither regular rhyme nor regular metre, and is still poetry because of its compression, imagery, rhythm and line arrangement.

> **Key point.** Always read a poem at least twice, aloud if possible. The first reading gives the general subject and mood; the second finds the persona, the structure, the devices and the attitude of the poet.

5.2 Types of poetry

Poetry is classified in two main ways: by purpose and manner (lyric, narrative, dramatic) and by named form (sonnet, ode, elegy and so on).

Lyric poetry

A **lyric** is a relatively short poem expressing the personal feeling or thought of a single speaker. The word comes from the lyre, a musical instrument, since early lyrics were sung. Lyrics deal with love, grief, joy, nature, faith, memory and protest. Most modern poems studied in schools are lyrics.

Narrative poetry

Narrative poetry tells a story in verse, with characters, setting and plot. It includes the epic and the ballad.

Dramatic poetry

In **dramatic poetry** the poet speaks through a character in a particular situation, often addressing a listener in the poem. The **dramatic monologue** reveals the speaker's character unconsciously: an arrogant chief who recounts his victories to a servant, boasting of his generosity while describing his cruelty, shows himself more truly than he intends.

Named forms

Form	Description
Sonnet	A poem of fourteen lines, usually in iambic pentameter, with a fixed rhyme scheme. The *Petrarchan* (Italian) sonnet has an octave (eight lines, rhyming abbaabba) and a sestet (six lines, with various schemes); the *Shakespearean* (English) sonnet has three quatrains and a closing couplet, rhyming abab cdcd efef gg.
Ode	A long, serious, dignified lyric addressed to a person, object or idea, praising it. Example: an ode to the Niger.
Elegy	A poem of mourning for the dead, usually thoughtful and consoling, often moving from grief to acceptance.
Dirge	A short song of grief for a funeral; simpler and more musical than an elegy.
Ballad	A narrative poem or song, simple in language, usually in short quatrains with a refrain and a story of love, adventure or tragedy.
Epic	A long narrative poem in elevated style about the deeds of a hero of great importance to a nation or people.
Pastoral	A poem about the countryside and rural life, often idealising shepherds or farmers.
Epigram	A short, witty, pointed poem or saying.
Limerick	A humorous five-line poem rhyming aabba.
Praise poem (panegyric)	A poem that praises a ruler, hero, ancestor or town, characteristic of African oral tradition, for example the Yoruba *oriki*.
Satire	A poem that ridicules vice or folly in order to correct it.
Haiku	A Japanese form of three lines, usually of 5, 7 and 5 syllables, capturing a single image of nature.

A **dirge** and an **elegy** are both mourning poems, but an elegy generally reflects on death and its meaning, while a dirge simply laments. An **ode** is serious and exalted, but a **praise poem** addresses a particular person or community.

Oral poetry in Africa

African poetry began in oral performance: praise-songs, dirges, hunters' chants (such as the Yoruba *ijala*), lullabies, work songs, riddles and incantations. Such poems are delivered by a performer with voice, drum, gesture and audience response, and they have features of repetition, parallelism and call-and-response. Modern African poets in English often borrow these features.

5.3 The structure of a poem

Line and stanza

A **line** (or **verse**) is a single row of words. A **stanza** is a group of lines forming a unit, like a paragraph in prose. Stanzas are named by their number of lines:

- **Couplet:** two lines, usually rhyming.
- **Tercet** (triplet): three lines.
- **Quatrain:** four lines, the commonest stanza.
- **Quintet** (cinquain): five lines.
- **Sestet:** six lines.
- **Septet:** seven lines.

- **Octave:** eight lines.

A poem in a single unbroken block is called **stichic**, as in much blank verse. A **refrain** is a line or lines repeated at intervals, for emphasis and musical effect. A **stanza break** usually marks a change of thought, image or speaker.

Rhyme

Rhyme is the repetition of identical sounds, usually at the ends of lines, beginning with the last stressed vowel: *night* and *light*, *market* and *carpet* (though the second is not a clean pair). Several kinds are distinguished.

- **End rhyme:** at the ends of lines.
- **Internal rhyme:** within a line: "the drum will come and hum".
- **Masculine rhyme:** a single stressed syllable rhymes (*stand*/*hand*).
- **Feminine rhyme:** a stressed syllable followed by an unstressed one (*sorrow*/*tomorrow*).
- **Half (slant, near) rhyme:** a partial echo (*moon*/*gone*).

The pattern of end rhymes is the **rhyme scheme**, marked with letters, giving the same letter to lines that rhyme. In the original quatrain below, the scheme is **abab**:

The harmattan comes with a dusty hand (a)
and lays on the roofs a coat of grey; (b)
the farmers look out on the thirsty land (a)
and wait for the rain to come their way. (b)

Lines 1 and 3 rhyme (*hand*, *land*), as do lines 2 and 4 (*grey*, *way*). Other common schemes are **aabb** (couplets), **abba** (enclosed rhyme) and **abcb** (the ballad scheme, with only alternate lines rhyming).

Rhythm and metre

Rhythm is the pattern of stressed (strong) and unstressed (weak) syllables, together with the pace and pauses of the lines. **Metre** is the regular, measured pattern of rhythm. The unit of metre is the **foot**, a group of two or three syllables with one stress. The principal feet are the following.

Foot	Pattern	Example
Iamb (iambic)	weak-strong (u /)	re-**LAX**, a-**BOVE**
Trochee (trochaic)	strong-weak (/ u)	**MAR**-ket, **RIV**-er
Anapaest (anapaestic)	weak-weak-strong (u u /)	in the **NIGHT**, un-der-**STAND**
Dactyl (dactylic)	strong-weak-weak (/ u u)	**MER**-ri-ly, **HAP**-pi-ly
Spondee	strong-strong (/ /)	**HEART-BREAK**

The **number of feet in a line** gives its name: monometer (one), dimeter (two), trimeter (three), tetrameter (four), **pentameter** (five), hexameter (six). Thus a line of five iambs is **iambic pentameter** (ten syllables, five stresses); a line of four trochees is trochaic tetrameter. **Scansion** is the marking of stresses in a line to find its metre. A poet may vary the metre for effect: a sudden spondee slows the line, and an extra weak syllable quickens it.

Blank verse is unrhymed iambic pentameter; **free verse** has no fixed metre or rhyme; **heroic couplet** is a pair of rhymed iambic pentameter lines.

Other structural features

- **Enjambment (run-on line):** the sense continues beyond the end of the line without a pause, creating flow, speed or hesitancy. Opposed to **end-stopped** lines, where the line ends with a natural pause or punctuation.
- **Caesura:** a pause within a line, often marked by punctuation, which can break the rhythm for emphasis.
- **Volta (turn):** a shift in thought or feeling, typically after the octave of a sonnet, or at the final couplet.
- **Parallelism and repetition:** repeating a grammatical pattern or phrase, strongly present in oral poetry.

5.4 Sound devices in outline

Poetry is an art of sound. The main sound effects, treated more fully in Chapter 6, are **alliteration** (repeated consonants at the start of words), **assonance** (repeated vowel sounds), **consonance** (repeated consonants within or at the ends of words), **onomatopoeia** (words imitating sounds) and **refrain**. In the original line "the slow stream slid through the silent stones", the repeated *s* sound (sibilance) suggests the quiet whisper of water.

5.5 Meaning in poetry: subject, theme, tone, mood and diction

Beyond structure, poetry must be understood for what it means.

- **Subject matter** is what the poem is about on the surface: a market, a funeral, a river.
- **Theme** is the central idea or message, expressed as a statement: "the poem shows that wealth cannot buy peace of mind".
- **Tone** is the poet's attitude towards the subject: tender, bitter, mocking, reverent, angry, resigned.
- **Mood** is the atmosphere produced for the reader: gloomy, joyful, tense, peaceful.
- **Diction** is the poet's choice of words: simple or elevated, local or foreign, concrete or abstract.
- **Imagery** is the pictures made in the mind by the words (see Chapter 6).

To find the theme, ask what the poem says about its subject, and what the title, the ending and the repeated words suggest. To find the tone, examine the diction and the tone of the verbs and adjectives.

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.1

Read this original poem and identify its type, its rhyme scheme and its theme.

Mother is gone, and the kitchen is cold;
the pot on the shelf has turned to grey.
We keep her stool, though it grows old,
and sweep the path she used each day.

Solution: The persona laments a dead mother, so the poem is an **elegy** (a lyric of mourning). The end words are *cold* (a), *grey* (b), *old* (a), *day* (b), so the rhyme scheme is **abab**. The theme is that grief endures in the objects and habits that remind us of the dead; the family clings to her memory. The tone is quiet and tender, and the mood is sorrowful.

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.2

Scan the line: "The river runs beneath the bridge", and name the metre.

Solution: Divide into syllables: the-RIV-er-RUNS-be-NEATH-the-BRIDGE. The stress falls on *riv*, *runs*, *neath*, and *bridge*; the pattern of weak-strong repeats: the-RIV | er-RUNS | be-NEATH | the-BRIDGE. There are four iambs (u /), so the line is **iambic tetrameter** (eight syllables, four stresses).

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.3

Give the rhyme scheme of the following original lines, and name the stanza: *The sun goes down on Lagos town, / the lamps are lit along the shore; / the hawkers pack their goods and frown, / for none will buy their wares once more.*

Solution: End words are *town* (a), *shore* (b), *frown* (a), *more* (b); the scheme is **abab**, in a four-line stanza, so it is a **quatrain**.

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.4

Explain the effect of enjambment in: *"We walked until the road gave way / to sand, and then to nothing, then / the sea."*

Solution: The sentence runs across line ends without stopping, so the reader is carried forward in the same way as the walkers move along the road. The sudden short phrase "the sea" in the last line, delayed by enjambment, produces surprise and a feeling that the way ends abruptly.

5.6 Poetry in African and other traditions

African poets writing in English face the question of language: how can poems in English carry the rhythms, proverbs and images of local languages? Many solve this by using parallelism, repetition, call-and-response, indigenous imagery (drums, rivers, masks, markets) and the voice of the town crier or the praise-singer. Their themes include

colonialism, independence, cultural identity, war, corruption, the city and the countryside, nature and love. Individual poets and collections are discussed in Chapters 7 and 8.

The English tradition provides the sonnet, the ode, the ballad, the elegy and blank verse, and shows the periods of Romantic poetry (emphasis on nature, imagination and feeling), Victorian poetry (moral and social concern) and Modern poetry (experiment, free verse, doubt). Caribbean and American poets blend English forms with local speech and rhythms such as the spiritual, the blues and calypso. These traditions are described in Chapter 9.

5.7 A method for reading a poem

1. **Read the title and the first lines.** What does the title promise? Does the poem fulfil or contradict it?
2. **Identify the persona and the situation.** Who speaks, to whom, about what?
3. **Find the subject, then the theme.**
4. **Examine the structure.** Note stanzas, rhyme, metre, enjambment and shifts.
5. **Examine the language.** Look for imagery, figures of speech and sound devices, and ask what each contributes.
6. **Judge the tone and mood.** Find the words that reveal feeling.
7. **State your response.** Say what the poem achieves, with evidence.

Key point. Never claim that a device "makes the poem beautiful". Say what it does: "the repetition of *drip* imitates the sound of the leaking roof and stresses the family's helplessness".

Exercise 5.1

1. Define poetry and say how the persona differs from the poet.
2. Name the form: a fourteen-line poem in iambic pentameter on love.
3. What is the difference between an elegy and an ode?
4. State the name for a four-line stanza and a six-line stanza.
5. Give the rhyme scheme of: *The moon is bright / above the hill; / the dogs of night / are barking still.*
6. What is a refrain and what is its effect?
7. Explain what is meant by iambic pentameter.
8. What is enjambment? What is a caesura?
9. Which kind of poem is a funeral song that lamentingly mourns a death?
10. What are the two parts of a Petrarchan sonnet?
11. Distinguish between tone and mood.
12. Name two features of African oral poetry that modern poets borrow.

Answers to Exercise 5.1

1. Poetry is compressed, patterned language expressing feeling and thought in lines and stanzas. The persona is the speaker created by the poet and may differ from the poet.
2. A sonnet.
3. An elegy mourns the dead; an ode praises, with a dignified tone, a person, thing or idea.
4. Quatrain; sestet.
5. abab (*bright*/*night*, *hill*/*still* alternate: lines 1 and 3 rhyme, lines 2 and 4 rhyme).
6. A line or group of lines repeated at intervals; it emphasises the idea and adds musical effect.
7. A line of five iambs (weak-strong feet), ten syllables with five stresses.
8. Enjambment is the running over of a sentence from one line to the next; a caesura is a pause within a line.
9. A dirge (or an elegy, if it also reflects on death).
10. An octave (eight lines) and a sestet (six lines).
11. Tone is the poet's attitude towards the subject; mood is the atmosphere created for the reader.
12. Any two of repetition, parallelism, call-and-response, praise-singing, proverbs, drum rhythms and refrains.

Exercise 5.2

1. Scan "The farmer plants the seed" and name its metre.
2. Read: *"Tomorrow is a rumour, / yesterday a stone."* State the likely theme.
3. What is the effect of ending a sonnet with a rhyming couplet?
4. A poem begins, "Go gently, Baba, to the river's end." What kind of poem is it likely to be?
5. Explain the effect of short, end-stopped lines in a poem about anger.
6. Which type of rhyme is shown in the pair *sorrow*/*tomorrow*?
7. How many lines does a limerick have, and what is its scheme?
8. State the metre of a line with six iambs.
9. Why might a poet use free verse in a poem about a broken city?

Answers to Exercise 5.2

1. The-FARM | er-PLANTS | the-SEED: weak-strong repeated three times, so iambic trimeter.
2. That the past is solid and fixed while the future is uncertain; the metaphors contrast the two.
3. It gives a sense of completion and often delivers the final turn of thought.

4. An elegy or dirge, for it addresses a dead man and bids him farewell.
5. They give a sharp, clipped rhythm that suggests tension and controlled fury.
6. Feminine rhyme (stress on the first syllable, followed by an unstressed one).
7. Five lines; aabba.
8. Iambic hexameter (alexandrine).
9. Free verse can reflect disorder and fragmentation, breaking regular rhythm to match the subject.

Chapter summary

- Poetry is compressed, patterned language arranged in lines and stanzas; the persona is the speaker, not necessarily the poet.
- The main kinds are lyric, narrative and dramatic poetry, with named forms such as sonnet, ode, elegy, dirge, ballad, epic, pastoral, epigram, limerick, haiku and praise poem.
- Stanzas are named by length: couplet, tercet, quatrain, quintet, sestet, septet and octave.
- Rhyme schemes are marked by letters; kinds of rhyme include end, internal, masculine, feminine and half rhyme.
- Metre is built from feet (iamb, trochee, anapaest, dactyl, spondee); five iambs make iambic pentameter, and scansion marks the stresses.

- Enjambment, caesura, volta and refrain shape rhythm and meaning.
- Meaning is explored through subject, theme, tone, mood, diction and imagery.
- To read a poem: identify the persona, subject, theme, structure, language and tone, and always state the effect of each device.

Chapter 6: Literary Devices I: Sound Devices and Figures of Speech

Every writer, whether a novelist, a playwright or a poet, works with the same raw material: words. What separates literary language from the language of a bank notice or a weather report is the deliberate shaping of those words so that they carry more than their plain dictionary meaning. A **literary device** (also called a **figure of speech** or a **stylistic device**) is any technique of language, sound or structure that a writer chooses in order to produce a particular effect on the reader. The effect may be beauty, emphasis, humour, shock, sympathy, or a clearer picture of an idea. Chapter 5 introduced sound devices in outline; this chapter treats them in full, together with the great family of **figures of speech**, that is, expressions in which words are used in a sense different from their ordinary literal sense.

The examination seldom asks you merely to name a device. It more often presents a line and asks, "What device is used in this line, and what is its effect?" A complete answer therefore has three parts: *name* the device, *quote* the words that show it, and *explain* what it contributes to meaning, mood or tone. Throughout this chapter, every illustration is an original composition written for teaching, and each is followed by a comment of the kind you should learn to write.

6.1 Sound devices

Poetry began as spoken or sung art, and prose too is heard in the mind. The sounds of words can echo meaning, create atmosphere and bind a passage together. The principal sound devices follow.

Alliteration

Alliteration is the repetition of the same consonant sound at the beginning of neighbouring words or stressed syllables. It is the sound that matters, not the spelling: "knife" and "nine" alliterate in sound, while "city" and "cat" do not.

Example: "The bold bus bounced and banged on the bridge." The repeated *b* is a heavy, explosive sound, which suits the jolting of a vehicle on a rough road. Alliteration gives a line music, makes it memorable (which is why proverbs and advertising slogans use it) and can imitate the action described.

Assonance

Assonance is the repetition of the same vowel sound in nearby words, with different surrounding consonants. *Example:* "The old toad rode slowly home alone." The long *o* sound runs through the line and produces a slow, mournful, drawling effect, which suits the slowness of the walker. Long vowels such as *o* and *oo* tend to slow a line and to create sadness or calm; short, high vowels such as *i* quicken it.

Consonance

Consonance is the repetition of a consonant sound within or at the end of words, not only at the beginning. *Example:* "The lone bell fell and rolled along the hall." The repeated *l* sound, inside and at the ends of words, produces a liquid, ringing quality. Consonance is the cousin of alliteration, and candidates often confuse the two: if the repetition occurs at the *start* of the words, call it alliteration; if it occurs in the middle or at the end, call it consonance.

Sibilance

Sibilance is a special kind of alliteration or consonance that repeats hissing sounds (*s*, *sh*, *z*, soft *c*). *Example:* "Soft snow sifted silently across the sleeping street." The hiss suggests quiet, whispering movement, as of falling snow, or, in other contexts, secrecy and menace, as of a snake.

Onomatopoeia

Onomatopoeia is the use of words whose sound imitates the sound they name: *buzz*, *hiss*, *thud*, *clang*, *splash*, *murmur*, *crackle*, *rustle*. *Example:* "The pot hissed, the fat spat, and the plantain crackled in the pan." The reader hears the kitchen. Onomatopoeia makes description vivid and immediate.

Rhyme, repetition, refrain and parallelism

Rhyme, treated in Chapter 5, is the matching of final sounds. **Repetition** is the deliberate recurrence of a word, phrase or idea for emphasis. Three particular forms are worth knowing:

- **Anaphora**: repetition of the same word or phrase at the beginning of successive lines or sentences. *Example:* "We built the roads; we dug the wells; we raised the walls that now you claim."
- **Refrain**: a line or phrase repeated at intervals through a poem or song, often at the end of each stanza, as in the call-and-response of many Nigerian folk songs.
- **Parallelism**: the use of similar grammatical structures in successive phrases to balance ideas. *Example:* "The strong rely on their arms; the wise rely on their counsel." Parallelism is common in proverbs, sermons and speeches.

Euphony and cacophony

Euphony is a pleasing, smooth, harmonious combination of sounds, produced by liquid consonants (*l*, *m*, *n*, *r*) and long vowels: "The mellow murmur of the morning stream." **Cacophony** is the deliberate use of harsh, jarring sounds, produced by hard consonants (*k*, *t*, *p*, *g*, *b*): "Crack, clatter and crash went the cracked cart." A poet uses euphony for peace and beauty, and cacophony for conflict, ugliness or chaos.

Key point. Never say only that "the poet uses alliteration". Always add the effect. A model sentence: "The repeated *s* in 'soft snow sifted silently' is sibilance, which imitates the hushed sound of falling snow and creates a peaceful mood."

6.2 Figures of comparison

The commonest figures of speech work by comparison: the writer asks the reader to see one thing in terms of another, so that an unfamiliar or abstract idea becomes concrete and vivid.

Simile

A **simile** is an *explicit* comparison between two unlike things, using a connecting word such as *like*, *as*, *than*, *as if* or *as though*. *Example:* "The market at noon was as loud as a thousand drums." A simile never means that the two things are identical; it points to one shared quality (here, noise). Be careful: "She is like her mother" is an ordinary comparison, not a simile, because the two things compared are of the same kind. A true simile compares things from different classes.

Metaphor

A **metaphor** is an *implied* comparison in which one thing is said to *be* another, without "like" or "as". *Example:* "The old teacher was a lantern in the dark village." The teacher is not literally a lantern; the metaphor transfers the lantern's qualities, light and guidance, to the teacher. A

metaphor is stronger and more compressed than a simile because it fuses the two ideas. In analysis, name the two parts: the **tenor** (the thing described, the teacher) and the **vehicle** (the thing it is compared to, the lantern).

Two special cases appear in advanced questions. A **dead metaphor** is one used so often that its figurative force has been lost ("the leg of the table", "the foot of the hill"). A **mixed metaphor** combines incompatible images and produces confusion or unintended comedy ("We must nip this snowball in the bud").

Extended metaphor and conceit

An **extended metaphor** develops a single comparison through several lines or even a whole poem. *Example:* "My grandmother's memory is a granary. Some bins are full of last season's stories; others stand empty and swept; and in the darkest corner the oldest grain, though dry, will still sprout if given rain." Here the granary image is carried through bins, emptiness, old grain and rain. A **conceit** is an elaborate, ingenious and often surprising extended comparison, associated with the seventeenth-century English Metaphysical poets, who compared, for instance, two separated lovers to the two legs of a drawing compass.

Personification

Personification gives human qualities, actions or feelings to non-human things, such as objects, animals or abstract ideas. *Example:* "The harmattan crept into the house and nibbled our ankles." The dry wind behaves like a mischievous creature. Personification makes nature and

ideas feel alive and helps the reader to share the writer's emotion. Some writers capitalise an abstraction ("Death came knocking") to personify it more strongly.

Apostrophe

Apostrophe (not to be confused with the punctuation mark) is a direct address to someone absent or dead, or to a thing, place or idea that cannot answer. *Example:* "O river Niger, carry my greeting to the sea!" It expresses strong feeling and is typical of odes, laments and prayers.

Metonymy and synecdoche

Metonymy replaces the name of a thing with the name of something closely associated with it. "The crown has issued a decree" (crown for the monarch); "The pen is mightier than the sword" (pen for writing, sword for military force); "Aso Rock has spoken" (the building for the Presidency). **Synecdoche** is a related figure in which a *part* stands for the *whole*, or the whole for a part: "Fifty hands worked the farm" (hands for workers); "All hands on deck"; "Nigeria won the match" (the whole nation for the team). The two are close, and an examiner who asks for one will usually choose clear cases.

Figure	Key feature	Signal	Short example
Simile	Explicit comparison	like, as, than	"Brave as a lion"
Metaphor	Implied comparison	X *is* Y	"Time is a thief"
Personification	Human traits given to non-human things	Verbs of human action	"The wind whispered"
Apostrophe	Address to the absent or lifeless	"O ..."	"O Death, where is your sting?"
Metonymy	Associated name replaces the thing	Substitution	"The press reported"
Synecdoche	Part for whole	Substitution	"Give us our daily bread"

6.3 Figures of emphasis, contrast and contradiction

Hyperbole

Hyperbole (or **overstatement**) is deliberate, obvious exaggeration used for emphasis or humour, never meant to be taken literally. *Example:* "I have told you a million times to close that gate." The effect is to intensify the speaker's irritation. In comic writing and in praise-singing, hyperbole is a principal tool.

Litotes and understatement

Understatement (**meiosis**) deliberately makes a thing seem smaller or less important than it is: "It was a bit of a scratch" (said of a deep wound). **Litotes** is a particular form in which an idea is expressed by

denying its opposite: "He is not a bad cook" (meaning, he is a very good cook); "She is no fool". Litotes is typical of the polite, ironic speech of many African and English speakers and often carries a quiet, humorous force.

Oxymoron

An **oxymoron** places two contradictory terms side by side in a single phrase: *bitter sweet*, *deafening silence*, *cruel kindness*, *living death*, *open secret*. It captures a situation of mixed or conflicting feeling. *Example:* "They parted with a cheerful sorrow, glad that the long war was over and sad that the friends it had made were gone."

Paradox

A **paradox** is a statement that seems self-contradictory or absurd on the surface but contains a deeper truth when examined: "The more he gave away, the richer he became"; "Less is more"; "To live, you must be ready to die." Distinguish it from the oxymoron: an oxymoron is a two-word contradiction (a phrase), whereas a paradox is a whole statement or situation whose apparent contradiction dissolves on reflection.

Antithesis

Antithesis sets two opposed ideas against each other in balanced phrases to sharpen the contrast: "Give me liberty, or give me death"; "It was the labour of kings and the toil of slaves"; "Man proposes, God disposes." Its effect is to make an argument crisp and memorable. A

related figure, the **chiasmus**, reverses the order of the two parts: "Ask not what your country can do for you; ask what you can do for your country."

Pun

A **pun** is a play on words that exploits two meanings of the same word, or two words of similar sound, usually for humour. *Example:* A tailor's sign reads, "We never sew a thing we cannot mend", or, of a baker, "He kneads the dough." Shakespeare and many Nigerian comic writers use puns in dialogue to show wit and to deliver double meanings.

Irony in brief

Irony, in which what is said or happens is the opposite of what is expected or meant, is so important that Chapter 7 treats it at length with satire, sarcasm and the related devices.

6.4 Figures of rhetoric and structure

Rhetorical question

A **rhetorical question** is asked for effect and not to receive an answer, since the answer is obvious or the speaker means to assert a point. "Who will stand with the farmer when the rains fail?" implies that nobody will. It involves the reader in the argument and persuades by suggestion.

Climax, anticlimax and bathos

Climax arranges ideas in rising order of importance or intensity: "He came, he saw, he conquered"; "We lost the harvest, the house, and finally our hope." **Anticlimax** reverses this and ends a rising series with something trivial, usually for comic effect: "She lost her fortune, her health, and her umbrella." When the drop from the lofty to the ridiculous is unintended, it is called **bathos** and counts as a fault.

Euphemism

A **euphemism** replaces a harsh, offensive or unpleasant word by a milder one: "He passed away" (died); "she is expecting" (pregnant); "the elderly" (the old). African speech, with its strong sense of respect, is rich in euphemism, especially concerning death. The opposite, a deliberately harsh term, is a **dysphemism**.

Periphrasis (circumlocution)

Periphrasis uses a roundabout phrase instead of a direct one: "the gentlemen of the long robe" for lawyers; "the fruit of the vine" for wine. It can be dignified, or comic when it is overdone.

Transferred epithet (hypallage)

In a **transferred epithet**, an adjective is moved from the noun it truly describes to another noun: "a sleepless night" (it is the person who is sleepless); "the condemned cell"; "a happy smile" (the person is happy). It compresses feeling into description.

Zeugma and syllepsis

In **zeugma**, one word, usually a verb, governs two others in different senses, producing wit: "She lost her keys and her temper"; "He opened the door and his heart."

Epigram

An **epigram** is a short, witty and memorable saying, often with a twist: "Experience is the name everyone gives to their mistakes." Proverbs are the folk equivalent.

Tautology and pleonasm

Tautology says the same thing twice in different words ("a free gift", "a necessary requirement") and **pleonasm** uses more words than needed ("I saw it with my own eyes"). In weak writing these are faults; in poetry and oratory they are sometimes used for emphasis.

6.5 Proverbs, idioms and figurative language

African literature in English is especially rich in **proverbs**, brief traditional sayings that express a general truth through a concrete image. Proverbs are not mere ornament; in Igbo, Yoruba and Hausa speech they are the means by which elders argue, judge and teach, and a speaker who uses them well gains authority. Examiners ask candidates to explain the meaning and function of a proverb in context. For instance, the invented proverb "A river that forgets its source will soon run dry"

means that people who forget their origins lose their strength, and its function in a story might be to rebuke a young man who despises his village after becoming rich in the city.

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning cannot be deduced from the individual words: "to kick the bucket" (to die), "to let the cat out of the bag" (to reveal a secret). Idioms are figurative, but they are conventional, whereas fresh figures such as an original metaphor surprise the reader.

6.6 Writing about devices

When you meet a figurative expression, ask three questions in order. **What is being compared or done?** (identify the device). **What qualities are carried across?** (the shared meaning). **What does this add to the passage?** (the effect on mood, character or theme). A good short paragraph might read: "In the metaphor 'the old teacher was a lantern in the dark village', the teacher is equated with a source of light. This suggests that he gives guidance and hope in a place of ignorance, and it makes the reader admire him." Avoid the common mistakes: listing devices without effects; mislabelling a metaphor as a simile; and treating every adjective as a figure of speech.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.1

Identify the devices in: "The scorching sun sat on our shoulders like a heavy sack, and the dust danced angrily along the road."

Solution: (1) "like a heavy sack" is a simile, since the sun's pressure is compared with a load and the word "like" is used; it conveys the oppressive weight of the heat. (2) "the dust danced angrily" is personification, as dust is given the human actions of dancing and anger; it makes the scene lively and hostile. (3) "scorching sun sat" is also alliteration and sibilance (*sc*, *s*), reinforcing the hiss of heat.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.2

Distinguish the devices in these two lines. (a) "His promises were smoke." (b) "His promises were like smoke."

Solution: (a) is a metaphor, because promises are said to *be* smoke; no connecting word is used. (b) is a simile, because the comparison is made explicit with "like". Both suggest that the promises vanish and cannot be grasped, but the metaphor is more forceful.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.3

Name the device and its effect in: "It was a deafening silence in the hall after the verdict."

Solution: "Deafening silence" joins two contradictory ideas, loud and quiet, and is therefore an oxymoron. The effect is to show that the silence was so complete and tense that it seemed to press upon the ears, expressing shock at the verdict.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.4

In the line "The crown trembled when the farmers marched, and a hundred hands lifted the gate", identify the figures of speech.

Solution: "The crown" stands for the king or the government, an object associated with the ruler replacing the ruler: metonymy. "A hundred hands" stands for a hundred men: synecdoche, since a part (hands) represents the whole person. "Trembled" given to the crown is also a slight personification.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.5

Comment on the sound of: "The thunder thudded, the tin roof throbbed, and a thousand drops drummed down."

Solution: The line has alliteration of *th* and *t* and *d* (thunder, thudded, tin, throbbed, thousand, drops, drummed, down). Words such as "thudded", "throbbed" and "drummed" are onomatopoeic. The hard, heavy plosive consonants produce a cacophonous, pounding rhythm, which makes the reader hear the storm beating on the roof.

Exercise 6.1

1. Name the device in "The wind whistled and the windows whimpered", and state its effect.
2. "My love is a red rose" is a simile. True or false? Explain.
3. What is the figure of speech in "Greedy fingers emptied the village purse"?
4. Identify the device: "He was not unkind to the beggar."
5. Name the figure: "Hail, O Moon, who watches over sleepless towns!"
6. What is the difference between alliteration and consonance?
7. "Never was so much owed by so many to so few" shows which device of structure?

8. Identify and explain: "I am so hungry I could eat a whole cow."
9. What device is "cruel kindness"?
10. "The kettle sighed, the stove grumbled, and the morning rose from bed." Name the main figure used.

Answers to Exercise 6.1

1. Alliteration of *w* with onomatopoeia ("whistled", "whimpered") and personification of the windows; it creates an eerie, restless mood.
2. False; it is a metaphor, since there is no "like" or "as".
3. Synecdoche (fingers for thieves) and transferred epithet or personification of greed; the main answer is synecdoche.
4. Litotes: it means he was kind, said by denying the opposite.
5. Apostrophe, a direct address to the moon, which cannot reply.
6. Alliteration repeats consonant sounds at the beginning of words; consonance repeats them within or at the end of words.
7. Antithesis or, more precisely, a climax built by parallelism; the commonly accepted answer is parallelism with emphasis through repetition of "so".
8. Hyperbole: the exaggeration stresses extreme hunger.
9. An oxymoron, because it joins contradictory words.
10. Personification, as the kettle, the stove and the morning are given human actions.

Exercise 6.2

1. Rewrite "The river is a snake" as a simile.
2. Which is a euphemism: "He died" or "He went to meet his ancestors"?
3. Classify "The pen has defeated more tyrants than the sword" for the words "pen" and "sword".
4. What is a conceit?
5. Explain the effect of anaphora in "We wept for the fields; we wept for the wells; we wept for the sons."
6. Identify the device in "She lost her job and her patience on the same day."
7. Give the effect of cacophony in a battle scene.
8. Is "Less is more" an oxymoron or a paradox? Why?
9. Explain what a mixed metaphor is and give an example.
10. In one sentence, state the three parts of a complete answer on a literary device.

Answers to Exercise 6.2

1. "The river is like a snake" (or "as winding as a snake").
2. "He went to meet his ancestors", since it softens the fact of death.
3. Metonymy: pen stands for writing or ideas, and sword for military force.

4. An elaborate, ingenious and extended comparison, typical of the Metaphysical poets.
5. The repetition builds an emotional rhythm, stressing the extent of the grief and the loss.
6. Zeugma, because "lost" governs two unlike objects in different senses.
7. Harsh sounds reflect noise, violence and chaos, so the reader feels the conflict.
8. A paradox: it is a whole statement that seems contradictory but is true; an oxymoron is only a two-word phrase.
9. A combination of incompatible images in one expression, such as "He has thrown a spanner in the milk of human kindness".
10. Name the device, quote the evidence, and explain the effect.

Chapter summary

- A literary device is a technique of language chosen to produce a particular effect; always name it, quote it and explain the effect.
- Sound devices include alliteration, assonance, consonance, sibilance, onomatopoeia, rhyme, repetition, anaphora, refrain, parallelism, euphony and cacophony.
- Figures of comparison include simile (explicit), metaphor (implied), extended metaphor, conceit, personification, apostrophe, metonymy and synecdoche.

- Figures of emphasis and contrast include hyperbole, understatement, litotes, oxymoron, paradox, antithesis, chiasmus and pun.
- Rhetorical and structural figures include the rhetorical question, climax, anticlimax, bathos, euphemism, periphrasis, transferred epithet, zeugma and epigram.
- Proverbs and idioms are important in African writing; explain both meaning and function in context.
- Avoid mislabelling and avoid listing devices without effects.

Chapter 7: Literary Devices II: Irony, Symbolism, Imagery, Allusion and Satire

Chapter 6 dealt with devices that work chiefly on the surface of language: the sound of a line, the comparison inside a phrase, the emphasis of a figure. This chapter turns to devices that operate at a larger scale. Irony, symbolism, imagery, allusion, allegory and satire do not merely decorate a sentence; they often shape a whole scene, a character or an entire work. They are also the devices on which examiners most like to build questions, because a candidate who can explain them shows that he or she has understood how a text means, and not just what it says.

Remember the three-part habit established in the previous chapter: *name* the device, *quote* the evidence, and *explain* the effect. The habit matters even more here, since these devices are subtle. A reader who writes only "the passage is ironic" has said almost nothing; a reader who says "the passage is ironic because the speaker praises the chief's generosity at the very moment the chief is seizing the villagers' farmland, so that the praise exposes his greed" has answered the question. As before, every illustrative passage in this chapter is an original composition.

7.1 Irony

Irony is a contrast between what is said and what is meant, or between what is expected and what actually happens, or between what a character knows and what the audience knows. Its common element is a gap, and the reader's pleasure and understanding come from perceiving that gap. There are three principal kinds.

Verbal irony

In **verbal irony** a speaker says one thing and means the opposite, or something markedly different. When a student has failed every paper and a friend remarks, "Well, you certainly worked hard this term," the words praise while the meaning condemns. Verbal irony shades into **sarcasm** when its purpose is plainly to wound or mock; all sarcasm is verbal irony, but not all verbal irony is sarcastic, since a writer may use it gently, to hint at a character's weakness without cruelty. **Understatement** (Chapter 6) is a close relative.

Example: "Chief Adewale, whose barn held enough yams to feed the village through three famines, sighed that he was only a poor man." The statement is untrue on the face of it; the reader recognises that the chief is either miserly or boastfully modest, and the irony exposes his character.

Situational irony

Situational irony occurs when the outcome of events is the reverse of what was expected or intended. A fire station that burns down, or a man who builds a high wall to keep thieves out and then finds himself locked in with no key, are classic cases. In fiction, situational irony frequently carries the moral point of a story: the greedy man loses everything by grasping too much, the proud wrestler is thrown by a boy.

Example: Mrs Okeke spends her savings on a lock so strong that no burglar can force it. On the night of the Christmas travel rush she loses the key, and the family sleeps on the veranda while the best lock in Enugu keeps them from their beds. What was meant to protect has imprisoned.

Dramatic irony

Dramatic irony arises when the audience or reader knows something that a character does not. It is the most important kind in drama, and the habit of the great tragedians. The audience knows that the man who is warmly welcomed into the king's house plans to murder him; every polite word spoken at the supper table now carries a sinister second meaning. This produces tension, because we watch a character walk towards a danger we can see, and pathos, because we pity him.

Example: In an original scene, a village head boasts, "No stranger will ever deceive me. I can read a man's heart like a book," while the audience has just watched his trusted adviser hand the secret map to the

invaders. The head's confidence is the very thing that makes his downfall painful.

Related forms: tragic irony, cosmic irony and Socratic irony

Tragic irony is dramatic irony in a tragedy, where a hero's words or acts bring about the opposite of what he intends: in the Greek tradition, a king who vows to find and punish the culprit behind a plague is, without knowing it, hunting himself. **Cosmic irony** (or irony of fate) suggests that destiny, or the gods, delight in frustrating human hopes.

> **Key point.** To identify irony, ask: what is expected, and what is delivered? In every ironic passage there are two layers, the surface (what is said or what happens) and the deeper layer (what is meant or what ought to have happened). Name the kind of irony, state both layers, and then state the effect: humour, criticism, tension or pity.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.1

Read the following original passage and identify the irony.

"Mallam Sani, the village's loudest preacher of honesty, spent the whole market day telling traders to count their change. That evening, when the tax collector asked him whether he had counted the offering box, he said he had never lost a single kobo, and quietly slid the box beneath his mat."

Solution: The irony is both verbal and situational in effect, but it is chiefly **situational irony tinged with hypocrisy**. 1. The surface layer: Sani is presented as the champion of honesty, and he declares that he has never lost a kobo. 2. The deeper layer: his action of hiding the box shows that he is dishonest. 3. The gap between his preaching and his conduct exposes him as a hypocrite. 4. Effect: the writer criticises moral pretence and invites the reader to distrust those who advertise their own virtue.

7.2 Symbolism

A **symbol** is an object, person, place, colour, action or event that stands for something beyond itself, usually an idea or feeling. The thing keeps its literal meaning in the story; but the writer arranges it so that it also carries a second, larger meaning. A dove is a bird, and also peace; a river is water, and also the passage of time or the flow of life; a locked door is wood and iron, and also a lost chance.

Symbols differ in how they are made. **Conventional (traditional) symbols** have a meaning that a whole community already shares: white for purity in many cultures, black for mourning or evil, the cross for Christianity, the crescent for Islam, the kola nut as a sign of welcome and peace-making among many Nigerian peoples, the palm frond as a sign of peace or the sacred. **Private (or contextual) symbols** take their meaning from the particular work. A broken calabash in one novel may signify a marriage that has failed; in another, it may be only a broken calabash. You decide by watching how the author repeats the object, describes it with unusual care, and places it at moments of significance.

A symbol that recurs through a work becomes a **motif**, a repeated image, phrase or idea that helps to knit the work's themes together. A motif of locust swarms returning at moments of crisis, for example, may suggest that disaster is cyclical. A **leitmotif** is a motif strongly tied to a character or theme, like the drum that sounds whenever the hero's fate is spoken of. A writer may also build a **symbolic setting**: a storm for inner turmoil, a river crossing for a change of life, a harmattan haze for confusion and uncertainty.

Example: "Old Mama Ngozi guarded the last seed yam in her barn, though the rains had failed and the barn was otherwise empty." The seed yam is literally food; symbolically, it stands for hope, the future and the continuity of the family. The reader senses that its fate will decide whether the household survives.

Key point. Do not call everything a symbol. A thing is symbolic when the text gives you reason to read it so: repetition, emphasis, unusual description, or placement at a turning point. When you claim symbolism, justify it with the evidence of the text, and say what the object stands for.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.2

An original story opens with a village well that has been dry for two seasons. In the last chapter, after a reconciliation between two feuding families, the well begins to flow again. Discuss the symbolism.

Solution: 1. Literally, the well is a water source. 2. Symbolically, water stands for life, renewal and blessing, so the dry well represents the spiritual and social barrenness caused by the feud. 3. Its return, timed with the reconciliation, shows that peace restores the community. 4. The motif is reinforced by the writer's repeated mention of the well at moments of quarrel and of reunion. 5. Effect: the theme that discord destroys and unity restores is made concrete rather than stated.

7.3 Imagery

Imagery is the use of words to create pictures or sense impressions in the reader's mind. It includes all the senses, not only sight. When the examiner asks, "What kind of imagery is used?", the usual answer names the sense to which the language appeals.

- **Visual imagery** appeals to sight: colour, shape, light, movement. "The sun hung like a copper pot above the roofs of Kano."
- **Auditory imagery** appeals to hearing: "The generators droned behind every wall, a grumbling chorus that never rested."
- **Olfactory imagery** appeals to smell: "The air of the market was thick with fried plantain, smoke and wet earth."
- **Gustatory imagery** appeals to taste: "The pepper soup burned her tongue and cleared her mind."
- **Tactile imagery** appeals to touch: "The cold tiles stung the soles of her feet."
- **Kinaesthetic imagery** suggests movement or muscle effort: "She staggered up the hill, each step dragging the whole weight of the market on her head."
- **Organic imagery** conveys internal sensations such as hunger, thirst or fatigue: "A hollow ache gnawed at his belly."

Writers often join senses in **synaesthesia**, where one sense is described in terms of another: "a bitter silence", "a loud shirt", "velvet music". Imagery may also be **literal** (an actual description) or **figurative** (a simile or metaphor creating the picture). When one group of images

dominates a work, we speak of a **pattern of imagery**: if a poem on city life uses images of machinery, hunger and decay again and again, the poet's attitude to the city is bleak.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.3

Identify the types of imagery in: "The bread seller's cry rose through the damp dawn, and the smell of warm dough drifted along the cold lane, soft as a hand upon the shoulder."

Solution: 1. "Cry rose" is auditory imagery. 2. "Damp dawn" and "cold lane" are tactile (temperature and moisture), also visually suggestive. 3. "Smell of warm dough" is olfactory. 4. "Soft as a hand upon the shoulder" is a simile that is also tactile, giving the smell a gentle, comforting touch. 5. Effect: the combination builds a warm, welcoming, intimate morning atmosphere against the cold lane.

7.4 Allusion

Allusion is an indirect reference to a person, event, text, myth or place outside the work, which the writer expects the reader to recognise. It works as a shortcut: a single phrase brings with it a whole story and its associations. Calling a ruthless ruler "a modern Nero" alludes to the Roman emperor reputed for cruelty; saying that a man has "the patience of Job" alludes to the biblical figure; calling an impossible task a "labour

of Hercules" alludes to Greek myth. Sources of allusion include the Bible, the Quran, classical mythology, history, earlier literature and, in African writing, proverbs, folktales, local history and traditional belief.

Do not confuse allusion with **illusion** (a false appearance) or **elusion** (the act of evading). The three words look similar and examiners enjoy testing them. Also distinguish allusion from direct **quotation**, where words are repeated openly. An allusion works only if the reader catches it; when answering, explain both what is alluded to and why it matters.

Example: "When the new vice-chancellor arrived with a ledger and a smile, the lecturers knew that Judas had come for dinner." The allusion to the betrayer of Christ at the Last Supper tells us that the new official is expected to betray those who welcome him.

7.5 Allegory and fable

An **allegory** is a story in which characters, events and settings systematically stand for abstract ideas, or for real people and events, so that the narrative has a surface meaning and a second, moral or political one running alongside it. The reader is meant to read at two levels. A **fable** is a short allegorical tale, often with animal characters, that ends in a moral. The tortoise of West African folklore, whose cunning wins him a feast but whose greed lands him in trouble, is an example; so are the tales of Aesop. In longer works, a farm run by animals may allegorise a nation's government, with each animal standing for a type of politician or citizen. Allegory differs from ordinary symbolism in being sustained: nearly every element has an assigned meaning.

7.6 Satire, parody and related forms

Satire is the use of humour, irony, exaggeration or ridicule to expose and criticise foolishness, vice or abuse, usually with the aim of provoking reform. The satirist is a moralist who laughs. Satire may target an individual (a corrupt minister), a class (the newly rich), an institution (a university or a church) or a whole society. It may be gentle (**Horatian satire**, light and amused) or savage (**Juvenalian satire**, bitter and angry).

Satirists have a toolkit of devices: **irony**, **exaggeration** and **caricature** (distortion of a person's features or traits for effect), **ridicule**, **sarcasm**, and **invective** (abusive language). **Parody** imitates the style of a serious work or writer in order to mock it; a poem written in the grand tones of an epic to describe a quarrel over a minibus seat is a parody. A **lampoon** is a harsh personal attack in writing. **Burlesque** mocks by treating a lofty subject in a low manner, or a low subject in a lofty manner. **Farce** is a comic form built on absurd situations, mistaken identity and slapstick, and sits next to satire in drama.

Nigerian writing has a strong satirical stream, targeting the corrupt politician, the fraudulent pastor, the clerk who demands "something small", the newly returned graduate with a foreign accent. Satire is commonly the tone of political novels and of stage plays about independence and its disappointments.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.4

Explain the satire in the following original lines: "The honourable member had promised the people a hospital, a road and a bridge. After four years he delivered a signboard on which all three were beautifully painted."

Solution: 1. The target is the politician who makes grand promises and fails to keep them. 2. The device is irony and understatement: the "delivery" is a mere painted signboard, an empty substitute. 3. There is also exaggeration, since the three promised works appear only as pictures. 4. The tone is mocking but controlled. 5. The effect is to expose election promises as hollow, and the writer implies that citizens deserve genuine service.

7.7 Tone, mood and atmosphere

These three terms are easily confused, and the examination uses them. **Tone** is the writer's or speaker's attitude towards the subject or audience, shown through word choice: admiring, scornful, tender, bitter, playful, solemn, ironic, nostalgic. **Mood** is the feeling that the passage creates in the reader: fear, sadness, calm, suspense. **Atmosphere** is the overall emotional climate of a work or scene, built from setting, description and event. The distinction is simple: tone belongs to the writer, mood to the reader, and atmosphere to the place or scene.

Closely related is **pathetic fallacy**, the attribution of human feelings to nature or the use of weather that mirrors the characters' emotions: rain falling as a character mourns, bright sunshine on a wedding morning, a storm that rages as a quarrel erupts. It differs from personification in that the nature is made to echo the human mood rather than merely being given a human trait.

Other devices that shape the emotional effect include **pathos**, the quality that evokes pity or sympathy (a child's suffering, an old man's loneliness); **suspense**, the tension created by uncertainty about what will happen; **humour**, which may be gentle wit, slapstick or satire; and **foreshadowing**, a hint about later events. **Juxtaposition** places two contrasting things side by side to sharpen both, as when a poem sets the luxurious dinner of a minister beside the empty bowl of a street child. **Anticlimax** and **bathos** (Chapter 6) handle sudden falls from the lofty to the trivial.

Words that describe tone

Build a vocabulary of precise tone words. A reverent tone shows deep respect; a nostalgic tone yearns for the past; a sardonic tone is bitterly mocking; a detached or objective tone shows no emotion; a didactic tone teaches or preaches; a lyrical tone is musical and emotional; a cynical tone distrusts human motives; an elegiac tone mourns; a jubilant tone rejoices. Choose the word that most exactly fits the evidence, and cite the words in the passage that justify it.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.5

State the tone and mood of the original passage: "The house on Ogunlana Street was empty now. Dust lay on the table where laughter had been, and the old radio, which once filled every evening with highlife, sat silent against the wall. She closed the door gently, as one closes the eyes of the dead."

Solution: 1. Tone: elegiac and tender (the writer mourns a lost happy past, and the closing simile shows respect). 2. Mood: sad, quiet and sombre; the reader feels loss. 3. Evidence: "empty", "dust", "silent", the contrast between "laughter" and "dust", and the closing simile with death. 4. Atmosphere: lonely and stilled.

7.8 Writing about these devices in the examination

Examination questions on devices are usually of three kinds. First, *identification*: "The expression 'the sun hung like a copper pot' is an example of (A) metaphor (B) simile (C) irony (D) paradox." The correct answer is B, because the comparison uses "like". Second, *explanation of effect*: "What does the writer achieve by repeating the image of the dry well?" Third, *distinction*: tone versus mood, allusion versus illusion, irony versus sarcasm, allegory versus symbolism. Keep these definitions sharp, and always check the exact wording of the option.

Beware of one common trap: a statement is not ironic merely because it is unexpected; there must be a contrast with what is meant or what ought to be.

Exercise 7.1

1. A character gives a long speech about his loyalty to the king, while the audience has seen him plotting the king's overthrow. This is (A) verbal irony (B) dramatic irony (C) paradox (D) pathos.
2. A poem describes a rich man's feast beside a beggar's empty bowl. The device is best called (A) juxtaposition (B) alliteration (C) onomatopoeia (D) apostrophe.
3. Name the type of imagery in "the sharp tang of lime and the hiss of frying onions".
4. Distinguish tone from mood in one sentence each.
5. "After years of saving for his son's school fees, the father learned that the school had been closed by the government on the very day he paid." Name the kind of irony.
6. Explain the difference between an allegory and a symbol.

Answers to Exercise 7.1

1. (B) dramatic irony: the audience knows what the speaker's listeners do not.
2. (A) juxtaposition: two contrasting things are placed side by side.

3. Gustatory (taste, "tang of lime") and auditory ("hiss"), with olfactory suggestion; it is a mixture of sense imagery.
4. Tone is the writer's attitude to the subject; mood is the feeling the passage arouses in the reader.
5. Situational irony: the outcome is the reverse of what the payment was meant to achieve.
6. A symbol is a single object or action standing for an idea; an allegory is a sustained story in which most elements carry a second meaning.

Exercise 7.2

1. "Oh, brilliant," said Nneka, as the generator died in the middle of the examination. Identify the device and the speaker's real meaning.
2. Which of the following is an allusion? (A) "He is as strong as a lion" (B) "He is a Samson among the porters" (C) "He ran like the wind" (D) "The wind whispered".
3. Explain why the weather in "Rain beat the roof all night as the family waited for news of the lost boy" is an example of pathetic fallacy or atmosphere, and say which fits better.
4. A poem ridicules a minister who spends millions on a ceremony and then opens a road with no surface. State the target of the satire and one device.
5. Read: "She planted the little neem tree on the day the war ended, and each year she measured it against her own height."

Suggest, with a reason, what the tree might symbolise.

6. What is the difference between parody and satire? Give one sentence for each.

Answers to Exercise 7.2

1. Verbal irony (sarcasm): she says "brilliant" but means that the failure of power is a disaster.
2. (B): Samson is a biblical figure famed for strength, so the phrase alludes to him; the others are simile or personification.
3. It fits atmosphere and pathetic fallacy: the rain echoes the family's anxiety; it is not personification because nature is not given human actions.
4. The target is wasteful, boastful officialdom (corruption); devices include irony and exaggeration (ceremony versus empty road).
5. The tree may symbolise hope and renewal after war, since it is planted when the war ends and its growth is measured over years.
6. Parody imitates the style of a work in order to mock it; satire criticises human folly or vice to provoke change, and may or may not imitate another work.

Chapter summary

- Irony is a gap between expectation and reality or between statement and meaning; its kinds are verbal, situational and

dramatic, with tragic and cosmic irony as related forms.

- A symbol is a thing that stands for an idea; conventional symbols are shared by a culture, private symbols take meaning from the work, and repeated symbols form motifs.
- Imagery appeals to the senses: visual, auditory, olfactory, gustatory, tactile, kinaesthetic and organic; synaesthesia mixes the senses.
- Allusion is an indirect reference to an outside person, event or text; do not confuse it with illusion or elusion.
- Allegory is a sustained two-level story; a fable is a short allegorical tale with a moral.
- Satire uses humour and irony to criticise vice and folly; its tools include exaggeration, caricature, sarcasm, parody, lampoon and burlesque.
- Tone is the writer's attitude, mood is the reader's feeling, atmosphere is the climate of a scene; pathetic fallacy ties weather to emotion.
- In answers, name the device, quote the evidence and explain the effect; never merely list.

Chapter 8: African Literature: Origins, Movements, Themes and Major Voices

African literature is the body of oral and written art produced by Africans, in African languages and in the languages that history brought to the continent, about African experience and about the human condition seen from African ground. It is old, since oral poetry, storytelling and drama existed on the continent long before any printing press; and it is young, since the modern written tradition, in English, French, Portuguese and the African languages, took its present shape only in the twentieth century. For the candidate, African literature is not an optional extra. It forms a large part of the prescribed reading, and examination questions ask about its themes, its characters, its settings, its language and the historical conditions that produced it.

This chapter gives the overall picture: where African literature comes from, how it developed, what its recurring concerns are, how African writers handle language, and who the major figures are. Chapter 9 will narrow the focus to Nigerian writing. Where a famous work is mentioned, the comments given are general and accurate summaries of its subject and significance, offered as models for the kind of knowledge you should have; you must still read your own prescribed texts closely, since the examination tests the specific details of those texts. All illustrative passages are original.

8.1 The roots: oral tradition

The oldest African literature was spoken, sung, chanted, drummed and danced. Chapter 1 described oral literature in general; here we note its significance as the root of the written tradition. Its forms include **folktales** (stories of tortoise, hare, spider and hunter, which entertain and teach), **myths and legends** (accounts of the origin of a people, a god or a hero), **proverbs** (condensed wisdom), **riddles** (puzzles that sharpen the mind), **songs and chants** (work songs, lullabies, funeral dirges, praise songs), **epics** (long narrative poems, such as the Sunjata epic of the Mande peoples of West Africa, sung by hereditary bards called *griots*) and **oral drama** (masquerades, festivals and ritual performance).

Oral literature is *communal* and *performed*. There is seldom a single author; a story is retold and reshaped by many tellers. It depends on the audience, who respond, clap, supply refrains and sometimes correct the teller. It uses repetition, refrain, rhythm, proverb, formulaic opening and closing lines, and music. It is *functional*: it teaches morals, preserves history, praises rulers, settles disputes and enforces custom. When modern writers adopt a proverb-rich style, a storyteller narrator, a chorus, or a folk song within the text, they are drawing on this inheritance.

Oral literature also has an enduring technique that readers should recognise in written works: the **frame** of the evening storytelling session, in which the narrator addresses the audience directly ("Listen, my children, and I will tell you how the tortoise lost his shell"), the **call**

and response pattern between leader and chorus, and the **trickster figure**, a clever and amoral character whose cunning wins him advantages and sometimes his downfall.

8.2 The stages of written African literature

It is helpful to view the written tradition in broad phases. The boundaries are not exact, and some writers belong to several phases, but the sequence makes the history intelligible.

Early written beginnings

Before the twentieth century, writing existed in several African regions: in Ethiopia (in Ge'ez), along the Swahili coast and in the Sahel (in Arabic script, and in Hausa and Fulani transcribed in Arabic characters, called *ajami*). In the nineteenth century, missionary education introduced the Roman alphabet to many languages, and the first generation of mission-educated Africans produced autobiographies, tracts, translations of religious texts and early novels. A famous example is the narrative of Olaudah Equiano, published in 1789, which recounts an African's capture, enslavement and eventual freedom; it belongs to the literature of the African diaspora and is a landmark of abolitionist writing.

The colonial period and the rise of the novel

In the first half of the twentieth century, as colonial rule and mission and government schools spread, African writers began to produce poetry, plays and fiction. Some early works, such as the Yoruba novel *Ogboju Ode Ninu Igbo Irunmale* by D. O. Fagunwa (1938), were written in African languages and drew on folk tradition. Others, such as Amos Tutuola's *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* (1952), a fantastical quest tale written in an unusual, free English, appeared in the early years of the modern era and attracted international attention. In French-speaking Africa, the **Négritude** movement of the 1930s to 1950s, associated with Léopold Sédar Senghor of Senegal, Aimé Césaire of Martinique and Léon Damas of French Guiana, proclaimed pride in black identity and culture as a reply to colonial contempt. Négritude poetry celebrates the African past, the African body and the African spirit; its critics, among them the Nigerian Wole Soyinka, said that an African did not need to proclaim his "tigritude", since a tiger does not announce that it is a tiger but simply leaps. That quip, widely retold, marks the difference between assertion and demonstration in art.

The nationalist and independence period

From the late 1950s, as one country after another won independence (Ghana in 1957, Nigeria in 1960, and many others in the same decade), writers took up the task of restoring dignity and offering a corrected history. Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* (1958) is the most famous example: it portrays Igbo society before and during the arrival of colonial rule, showing it as a complex and orderly culture, with its own

laws, religion, art and failings, and not the primitive darkness described by European writers. Other works of the period include Camara Laye's *The African Child* (Guinea, French original 1953), a gentle memoir of childhood, and Ferdinand Oyono's satirical *Houseboy* (Cameroon), which shows the colonial household from a servant's view.

The disillusionment period

Within a few years of independence, many writers recorded disappointment. Leaders who had promised freedom turned into tyrants or thieves, and coups, civil wars and corruption followed. Achebe's *A Man of the People* (1966) satirises a corrupt politician and ends with a military coup; Ayi Kwei Armah's *The Beautyful Ones Are Not Yet Born* (Ghana, 1968) shows a man struggling to remain honest in a society rotted by bribery; Soyinka's plays and poems attack abuse of power; and Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o of Kenya turned increasingly to the failures of the post-colonial elite and the sufferings of peasants and workers. This period is often called the literature of **post-colonial disillusionment**.

Contemporary writing

The most recent writing is wide-ranging. It deals with civil war, migration and exile, the struggle of women, urban life, sexuality, religion, family, climate and the global African diaspora. Writers such as Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, Ben Okri, Tsitsi Dangarembga (Zimbabwe), Nuruddin Farah (Somalia), J. M. Coetzee and Nadine Gordimer (South Africa), and many others have reached international

readerships. It is typically more varied in form, with experiments in narration, mixture of languages and cross-genre writing, than the early nationalist literature.

Key point. Learn the phases as a sequence: oral roots; early written and colonial period; Négritude and nationalist writing; independence and cultural recovery; post-independence disillusionment; contemporary diversity. A question that asks why writers of a certain period wrote as they did is asking you to connect literature with history.

8.3 Regions and literary traditions

Africa is a vast continent, and its literary traditions vary with region, language and history. A useful overview follows.

Region	Main literary languages	Characteristic concerns	Representative figures
West Africa	English, French, Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo, Twi and others	Culture clash, colonial rule, corruption, tradition and change, civil war	Achebe, Soyinka, Ama Ata Aidoo, Senghor, Armah, Mariama Bâ
East Africa	English, Swahili, Kikuyu, Somali	Land, colonial violence, class conflict, language politics	Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, Okot p'Bitek, Nuruddin Farah
Southern Africa	English, Afrikaans, Zulu, Xhosa, Sotho, Shona	Racial segregation and apartheid, exile, land, reconciliation	Alan Paton, Nadine Gordimer, Es'kia Mphahlele, Dangarembga, Coetzee
North Africa	Arabic, French	Identity, colonialism, modernity, tradition	Naguib Mahfouz (Egypt), Tahar Ben Jelloun (Morocco)
Central Africa	French, Lingala, others	Colonial exploitation, dictatorship, identity	Various Congolese and Cameroonian writers

Do not memorise this table as a list of names only; attach each name to a typical concern. Soyinka was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1986, the first African so honoured; Naguib Mahfouz received it in 1988, Nadine Gordimer in 1991 and J. M. Coetzee in 2003, and later laureates have included Abdulrazak Gurnah of Tanzania (2021).

8.4 Major themes in African literature

The themes of African literature are many, but a few return again and again. A candidate who can identify them can also discuss almost any text.

- **Culture conflict.** The collision between traditional African ways and the colonial or Western ways that followed. Characters stand between two worlds, and the result is tragedy, confusion or, rarely, reconciliation. The tragic hero is often a man who cannot adapt.
- **Colonialism and its effects.** Land seizure, forced taxation, missionary pressure, loss of authority by chiefs, new courts and the creation of a class of clerks and interpreters. Writers show colonialism not only as political domination but as cultural and psychological injury.
- **Corruption and abuse of power.** A staple of post-independence writing, shown through bribery, electoral fraud, embezzlement, nepotism and the contempt of the ruling class for ordinary people.
- **Tradition and modernity.** The pull between the old (elders, customs, spiritual belief) and the new (schools, cities, money, new religions). Many works refuse a simple choice between them.
- **The position of women.** Marriage, motherhood, childlessness, polygamy, education and economic independence. Women writers, including Flora Nwapa, Buchi Emecheta, Ama Ata Aidoo, Mariama Bâ and Adichie, have given women's own accounts of such matters, challenging earlier male-centred images.

- **Racial prejudice and apartheid.** The central subject of much South African writing, which examines segregation, humiliation, resistance and reconciliation.
- **War and violence.** Civil wars, coups and ethnic conflicts, and their human cost, in the Nigerian, Rwandan, Sierra Leonean and other experiences.
- **Identity, exile and migration.** The search for a self when one is divided between homeland and elsewhere, a prominent theme in diaspora writing.
- **Religion and belief.** The relationship of traditional religion to Christianity and Islam, and the role of the supernatural, ancestors and fate.
- **Poverty, urban life and the generational gap.** The migration of youth to cities, loss of respect for elders, and the stresses of survival.

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.1

In an original novel, a village yam farmer, Baba Tunde, loses his land to a company backed by a colonial official. His son, Kunle, goes to the mission school, learns English, and returns as a court clerk who helps the official collect taxes. Baba Tunde dies bitter. Identify two themes and explain how each is developed.

Solution: 1. *Colonialism*: the loss of land to a company supported by an official shows political and economic domination. 2. *Culture conflict and generational divide*: the son's education and his work for the official place him on the other side from his father, showing how colonial education separates children from their roots. 3. The father's bitter death suggests the cost borne by the older generation. 4. The writer develops the themes by contrast of the two characters, not by direct comment.

8.5 Language and style in African writing

A great debate concerns the language of African literature. Many African writers write in English, French or Portuguese, languages inherited from colonial rule, because they were taught in them and because these languages give access to a wide readership. Others, like Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o (who decided to write mainly in Gikuyu from the late 1970s) and the Yoruba novelist Fagunwa, believe that African literature should be written in African languages. Achebe replied that an African writer could use English, so long as he bent it to carry African

experience: "an English that is still in full communion with its ancestral home but altered to suit its new African surroundings". In this view, the writer who uses a borrowed tongue transforms it.

Several stylistic features follow from this. African writers often use **proverbs**, as when an elder says that the lizard that jumped from the high iroko tree to the ground said that if nobody praised him he would praise himself; the proverb comments on a character's self-praise. They use **translated idiom**, English that reproduces the shape of an African-language expression ("he has no hands to hold the matter"); **code-switching** and **Pidgin English**, which place characters in their social setting; **songs, chants and praise names**; **proverbial or storytelling narrators**; **folk tales embedded in narrative**; **ritual and festival scenes**; and **repetition** and **parallelism** borrowed from oral performance. The tone may be ironic or tragic. Note that style is a way of expressing the culture, and not merely decoration.

8.6 African poetry and drama

African poetry grew from oral song and from the colonial school. It includes the Négritude poetry of Senghor and David Diop; the dense, modernist verse of Christopher Okigbo, Nigeria; the public and political poems of Soyinka, John Pepper Clark and Okot p'Bitek, whose *Song of Lawino* (Uganda, written in Acholi and then in English) is a long poem in the voice of an unlettered wife defending her African culture against her husband's scorn; the work of the Ghanaian Kofi Awoonor, who drew on Ewe dirge forms; and the poems of South African and diaspora

writers who protested against oppression. Typical themes are the return to roots, nature, love, death, exile, protest and the colonial wound. Typical devices are imagery from the African landscape, repetition, refrain and proverb.

African drama likewise draws on ritual and festival: masquerade, dance, mime, drumming, storytelling, chorus and audience participation. Plays in English tend to mix these with the forms of Western stage drama. Wole Soyinka's *The Lion and the Jewel* (first performed 1959, published 1963) is a comedy about a village belle, her suitors and the clash of old and new; his *Death and the King's Horseman* (1975) is a tragedy about ritual duty, based on an actual event in the colonial period. Ola Rotimi's *The Gods Are Not to Blame* (1971) retells a Greek tragedy of fate in a Yoruba setting. Ghanaian Efua Sutherland's *The Marriage of Anansewa* draws on the Anansegoro storytelling tradition, with a spider trickster as its model. Details of such works belong to your own reading; the point here is that African drama brings the oral and the written together.

> **Key point.** Whenever you read an African text, ask four questions: What historical situation lies behind it? What cultural values are at stake? Which oral forms does it borrow? How does the writer handle language? These questions will help you to answer almost any question on setting, theme, style or characterisation.

8.7 Reading African prose: a worked approach

African prose fiction frequently takes the form of the **historical novel** (set in the past, to recover it), the **novel of disillusionment** (set after independence), the **bildungsroman** (novel of growth), the **war novel**, the **women's novel of domestic and social life** and the **fantasy or magical-realist narrative**, in which the supernatural is treated as part of ordinary life. When you read a passage, locate it: Is it precolonial, colonial or post-colonial? Who holds power in it? What is the writer's attitude, and how can you tell?

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.2

Read this original extract and comment on it.

"The elders sat under the great tree, as they had since the first settlers came, and the District Officer sat above them on a chair carried from the rest house. When an elder spoke of the land of his fathers, the interpreter, who was a boy half the elder's age, turned his words into something smaller. The Officer nodded, wrote one line, and the matter of the river farms was settled."

Solution: 1. Setting and period: colonial. 2. The chair "above" the elders signals the colonial official's power over traditional authority. 3. The interpreter, young and sharing the official's world, "turns the words into something smaller", which shows how colonial administration distorted African voices. 4. "Wrote one line": the huge matter of land is reduced to one line, an indictment of bureaucratic contempt. 5. Tone: restrained, ironic, quietly accusing. 6. Theme: colonial injustice and the erosion of indigenous authority.

8.8 African literature in the examination

The UTME paper treats African literature in two ways. Questions on *general knowledge* ask for the author of a famous work, the period of a movement, the meaning of a term (Négritude, griot, oral tradition) or the typical themes of a region. Questions on *prescribed texts* ask about plot, setting, characters, themes and style. Prepare for the first by learning the

main figures, their countries and their best-known works; prepare for the second by close reading and by writing short summaries of each text's plot, major characters, themes, setting and language, together with two or three episodes you can recall in detail.

Keep your facts exact. Associate Achebe with Nigeria and *Things Fall Apart* (1958); Soyinka with the Nobel Prize (1986), *The Lion and the Jewel* and *Death and the King's Horseman*; Ngũgĩ with Kenya; Senghor with Senegal and Négritude; Armah and Aidoo with Ghana; Okot p'Bitek with Uganda; Paton and Gordimer with South Africa. Never invent an author or a title; if you do not remember, reason from the clue in the question (a theme, a country, a date).

Exercise 8.1

1. The movement that celebrated black identity and culture in reply to colonial contempt was (A) Realism (B) Négritude (C) Romanticism (D) Modernism.
2. A West African hereditary bard who preserves history and praises rulers in song is called a (A) griot (B) chorus (C) scribe (D) clerk.
3. Name two features of oral literature that appear in modern written African works.
4. Why did many writers of the 1960s turn from the theme of colonial injustice to the theme of corruption?
5. Who was the first African to win the Nobel Prize in Literature, and in what year?

6. Explain what is meant by "culture conflict" in African literature, with one example from your own reading.

Answers to Exercise 8.1

1. (B): Négritude, associated with Senghor, Césaire and Damas.
2. (A): the griot, a bard of the Mande and neighbouring peoples.
3. Any two: proverbs, folktales, songs and chants, repetition and refrain, storyteller narrator, call and response.
4. Because independence was followed by corrupt, often tyrannical, local rulers; the writers' target changed from the foreign ruler to the failures of the new elite.
5. Wole Soyinka, in 1986.
6. It is the clash between traditional and Western (colonial) ways of life, seen in a character who is torn or destroyed between them; the example must come from the candidate's text.

Exercise 8.2

1. Match each writer with a country: Okot p'Bitek, Mariama Bâ, Nadine Gordimer, Armah. (Choose from Ghana, Senegal, South Africa, Uganda.)
2. Name the stage of African writing to which Négritude and the early nationalist novels belong, and say what the writers tried to do.

3. Explain what Achebe meant by using English in a way that was "altered to suit its new African surroundings".
4. Read: "When the chief sneezed, the whole council caught a cold." Suggest what this expresses about the relationship between the chief and the council, and name the device.
5. Give three typical themes of South African literature of the apartheid period.
6. Why is the folk trickster, such as the tortoise, useful to a writer of satire?

Answers to Exercise 8.2

1. Okot p'Bitek: Uganda; Mariama Bâ: Senegal; Nadine Gordimer: South Africa; Armah: Ghana.
2. The cultural-recovery or nationalist stage; writers tried to restore dignity to African culture and to correct colonial distortions of African history.
3. He meant that African writers should bend the English language, with proverbs, idiom and rhythm from African speech, to express African experience while still keeping it understandable.
4. The council slavishly imitates and fears the chief; the device is hyperbole and humorous exaggeration used in satire.
5. Any three: racial segregation, injustice, humiliation, resistance, exile, land, reconciliation.
6. The trickster is cunning, shameless and entertaining; through him a writer can expose greed, pride and authority without direct attack,

since the folk tale gives cover and humour.

Chapter summary

- African literature began in oral forms (folktale, proverb, riddle, song, epic, ritual drama) that are communal, performed and functional, and that still influence written works.
- The written tradition moved through early and colonial writing, Négritude and nationalist writing, post-independence disillusionment and contemporary diversity.
- Major regions have distinct concerns: West Africa (culture clash, corruption), East Africa (land, language politics), Southern Africa (apartheid, reconciliation), North Africa (identity and modernity).
- Recurring themes are culture conflict, colonialism, corruption, tradition and modernity, women's roles, racism, war, exile, religion and poverty.
- The language debate concerns writing in European or African languages; African writers of English adapt it with proverbs, idiom, Pidgin and oral forms.
- African poetry and drama use imagery, refrain, ritual, chorus, music and dance, joining oral and written methods.
- Know authors, countries and works precisely; read each prescribed text closely, since the examination tests detail.

Chapter 9: Nigerian Literature: Prose, Drama and Poetry

Nigerian literature is the most celebrated in modern Africa, and for the Nigerian candidate it deserves the closest attention, for the reason that the set texts in the examination so often come from it. A Nigerian text is not simply a story or a poem; it is a witness to the history of the country, to its peoples, its languages, its institutions and its changing hopes. The writer who sets a novel in an Igbo village in the 1890s, or a play in a Lagos suburb in the 1960s, or a poem in the muddy creeks of the Niger Delta, is offering a view of the nation from within.

This chapter surveys Nigerian writing by genre and period. It presents the main authors, the typical subjects of their work, the techniques that distinguish them, and the themes you will most often meet. As in Chapter 8, the notes on named works are accurate general summaries, designed to give you the background knowledge that examination questions presuppose. Your own prescribed texts must be read directly and in detail. The illustrative passages and scenes are original compositions.

9.1 Historical overview

Nigeria is a federation of more than two hundred and fifty ethnic groups, with Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba and Igbo as the largest, speaking over five hundred languages. Its literary history can be grouped into stages.

1. **Oral and precolonial tradition.** Every Nigerian people has its own oral literature: Yoruba *ijala* (hunters' chants), *oriki* (praise poetry), *ese Ifa* (the verses of the Ifa divination corpus) and *alo* (folktales); Igbo proverbs, folktales and the poetry of masquerades and festivals; Hausa praise songs, tales and riddles; Ijaw, Efik, Tiv, Edo and other forms. In the north, a written tradition in Arabic and in Hausa and Fulfulde in Arabic script, such as the poems of the early nineteenth-century Sokoto reformers, is also old.
2. **Early written beginnings and the mission press (before 1950).** Missionary schools and newspapers produced translations, hymns, school readers and early writing in Yoruba, Igbo, Hausa and English. The Yoruba novelist D. O. Fagunwa wrote in his own language. Abubakar Imam's Hausa work *Magana Jari Ce* (1930s) is a famous collection of tales.
3. **The birth of the Nigerian novel in English (1950s).** Cyprian Ekwensi's *People of the City* (1954) and Amos Tutuola's *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* (1952) opened the era. Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* (1958) became the landmark.
4. **Independence and cultural nationalism (late 1950s to mid-1960s).** Writers recovered pride in the African past, interpreted the encounter with Europe, and recorded the hopes of the new state.
5. **Civil war and disillusionment (1966 onward).** The coups of 1966, the war of 1967 to 1970 and military rule produced a literature of anger, satire, protest and pain.
6. **Contemporary period (1980s to the present).** A new generation, including many women and many writers living abroad, deals with

corruption, military and civilian misrule, gender, migration, religion, violence and the oil economy.

9.2 Nigerian prose fiction

The pioneers

Amos Tutuola (1920–1997) wrote *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* (1952), the story of a man who journeys into the land of the dead to bring back his tapster. It draws on Yoruba folktale and supernatural motifs, and its English is deliberately non-standard, which lent it a strange energy and also a controversy about whether it was authentic or naive. **Cyprian Ekwensi** (1921–2007) wrote of the urban, modern Nigerian city: *People of the City* (1954) and *Jagua Nana* (1961) follow characters in Lagos amid its music, nightlife and moral hazards, in a quick, popular, journalistic style.

Chinua Achebe

Chinua Achebe (1930–2013), from Ogidi in Igboland, is the central figure. His novels form a chain across the history of his people: *Things Fall Apart* (1958) portrays a proud Igbo clan, and its hero Okonkwo, at the moment of contact with missionaries and colonial government; *No Longer at Ease* (1960) follows Okonkwo's grandson, Obi, a Western-educated civil servant destroyed by bribery and conflicting loyalties; *Arrow of God* (1964) concerns the priest Ezeulu and the clash of religious and political authority in the 1920s; *A Man of the People* (1966) satirises a corrupt politician in a newly independent state; and

Anthills of the Savannah (1987) shows educated men and women in a military dictatorship. Technically, Achebe is famous for restraint, for the use of proverbs ("proverbs are the palm-oil with which words are eaten", as a character says), for narrators who are objective yet quietly ironic, and for the tragic structure in which a man's pride and rigidity, in a moment of change, undo him.

Other major novelists

Elechi Amadi (1934–2016), in *The Concubine* (1966), writes about a rural Igbo community in which a beautiful woman is bound to a sea god, and the men who love her die; it explores fate, belief and the force of the supernatural, in a calm and controlled style. **Flora Nwapa** (1931–1993) wrote *Efuru* (1966), generally regarded as the first novel in English by an African woman to be published in Britain, about a Igbo woman, a trader whose marriages fail and who finds a quiet fulfilment in her devotion to a lake goddess; Nwapa wrote of women's economic strength and of the suffering that childlessness could bring. **Buchi Emecheta** (1944–2017) wrote *The Bride Price* (1976), *Second-Class Citizen* (1974) and *The Joys of Motherhood* (1979), which treat the costs of motherhood, marriage customs and the migrant woman's life; her best-known theme is that the woman who gives everything to her children may be rewarded with neglect. **Wole Soyinka's** novels, *The Interpreters* (1965) and *Season of Anomy* (1973), and his memoir *Aké* (1981) show an intelligent, allusive, often satirical style. **Ben Okri** won the Booker

Prize in 1991 for *The Famished Road*, a novel of a spirit child, a Lagos-like city and political turmoil, which blends realism and the supernatural.

The newer generation

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie (born 1977) is the leading voice of the newer generation. *Purple Hibiscus* (2003) shows a young girl, Kambili, growing up in a household dominated by a devout and violent father, and her gradual discovery of freedom; *Half of a Yellow Sun* (2006) is set in the Biafran war and traces the lives of characters on different sides of class and culture; *Americanah* (2013) examines race, migration and love. **Helon Habila** (*Waiting for an Angel*, 2002) satirises military rule; **Chigozie Obioma** (*The Fishermen*, 2015) uses a family story to explore prophecy and violence; **Sefi Atta**, **Teju Cole** and **Ayobami Adebayo** are among others of the contemporary scene. Their work is often marked by a first-person or limited point of view, an intimate treatment of the family, and a global awareness.

> **Key point.** Pair each Nigerian novelist with a period, a setting and a theme. Achebe: Igbo history from the colonial encounter to the post-independence state. Tutuola: folk fantasy. Ekwensi: urban life. Amadi: village belief and fate. Nwapa and Emecheta: women's lives. Adichie: war, family and migration.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.1

Read this original extract and answer the question that follows: "Obiora wore his new suit to the council meeting, and the elders looked at the cloth, not at the man. 'He has returned from the school of the white man,' the eldest said, 'and brought nothing back but a coat.' Obiora laughed politely, but his laughter did not reach his eyes." What theme does the passage suggest, and how is it presented?

Solution: 1. Theme: culture conflict, especially the gap between the Western-educated young man and the traditional elders. 2. Presentation: the elders' remark that he has "brought nothing back but a coat" uses a mocking, understated criticism; the suit is a symbol of foreign influence. 3. The narrator's note that the laughter "did not reach his eyes" suggests his embarrassment and inner isolation. 4. Effect: it evokes sympathy for a character who belongs fully to neither world.

9.3 Nigerian drama

Nigerian drama grew from two roots: indigenous performance (the Yoruba masquerade and *alarinjo* travelling theatre, the Igbo masquerade and festival plays, the Ijaw and Efik rituals, the Hausa *wasan* performance) and the Western stage introduced by schools and churches. It matured in the early 1960s.

Wole Soyinka

Soyinka (born 1934) is the major dramatist. His plays include *A Dance of the Forests* (1960), written for the independence celebrations, which warns that the new nation is as flawed as the old; *The Lion and the Jewel* (1963), a comedy about the village beauty Sidi, the schoolteacher Lakunle (a man infatuated with Western manners and ridiculous in his pretensions) and the shrewd old chief Baroka, who wins her; *The Trials of Brother Jero* (1960s), a satire on a charlatan prophet; *The Road* (1965), a metaphysical drama on death and the transitions of life; *Kongi's Harvest* (1965), a satire on dictatorship; and *Death and the King's Horseman* (1975), a tragedy in which the Yoruba king's horseman, Elesin, is expected to die in ritual after the king's death, hesitates, and is overtaken by tragic consequence. Soyinka's drama draws on Yoruba myth and ritual, mixes poetry with prose, and uses music, dance and symbol. He was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1986.

John Pepper Clark

J. P. Clark (later Clark-Bekederemo, 1935–2020) wrote *Song of a Goat* (1961), a tragedy of a childless man, and its sequel *The Masquerade* (1964); *The Raft* (1964), in which four men adrift on the river are an image of the country adrift; and *Ozidi* (1966), based on an Ijaw epic performed over several days. Clark's work shows the influence of Greek tragedy but is rooted in Ijaw myth and the river landscape.

Ola Rotimi

Rotimi (1938–2000) wrote *The Gods Are Not to Blame* (1971), which transposes the tragedy of the king who unknowingly kills his father and marries his mother into a Yoruba kingdom; *Kurunmi* (1969) and *Ovonramwen Nogbaisi* (1971), historical plays about the fall of the Yoruba and Benin leaders; and *Our Husband Has Gone Mad Again* (1966), a satirical comedy about a politician, Lejoka-Brown. Rotimi is notable for staging language: he uses proverbs, Pidgin and different registers to show class and character, and his plays are written to be performed to a broad audience.

Later dramatists

Femi Osofisan (*Once Upon Four Robbers*, *Morountodun*), whose plays are politically radical and borrow from folk tradition to question poverty and abuse of power; **Zulu Sofola** (*Wedlock of the Gods*), one of the first notable Nigerian women playwrights, who explored the conflict between tradition and love; **Tess Onwueme**; **Bode Sowande**; and **Tunde Fatunde** are among others who extended the range. Popular theatre, television drama and Nollywood film today carry the same themes to a mass audience.

Among common characteristics of Nigerian drama are: the use of ritual, myth and festival; the use of dance, music and mime; the use of proverbs and local idiom; the figure of the tragic hero, destroyed by fate, pride or duty; comic characters in the tradition of the trickster; and political satire.

9.4 Nigerian poetry

Nigerian poetry in English emerged in the late 1950s and early 1960s from the universities, notably Ibadan, and from the pages of the journal *Black Orpheus*. It may be grouped by generation.

The first generation includes **Wole Soyinka** (*Idanre and Other Poems*, 1967, and the prison poems *A Shuttle in the Crypt*, 1972), **Christopher Okigbo**, **J. P. Clark** and **Gabriel Okara**. Okigbo (1932–1967) wrote complex, musical, allusive poetry, collected in *Labyrinths* (1971) and including the sequences *Heavensgate* and *Limits*. He drew on the Igbo goddess Idoto, on classical and Christian references, and on modernist technique. He joined the Biafran army and was killed in 1967, so that he has become a symbol of the cost of the war. Gabriel Okara (1921–2019) is known for *The Voice* (a novel) and for poems such as "Piano and Drums", which contrasts the pulse of the African drum with the sophisticated pianist's music, to depict the conflict of tradition and Western civilisation. Clark's poems are direct and controlled; in "Night Rain" and "Abiku", for example, the African household and its beliefs are given a clear image.

The second generation includes **Niyi Osundare** (*Village Voices*, *The Eye of the Earth*, *Waiting Laughters*), whose accessible, oral-based poems champion the common man and attack exploitation; **Odia Ofeimun**; **Tanure Ojaide**, with his Niger Delta poems; **Ezenwa-Ohaeto**; and **Funso Aiyejina**. Their poetry is public and political, often addressing military rule, economic hardship, environmental damage in the Delta and the corruption of the state.

The younger generation includes **Remi Raji**, **Obiwu**, **Uche Nduka**, **Ogaga Ifowodo** and many others, whose work ranges from protest to the private and the experimental, and often draws on performance and spoken-word forms.

The qualities of Nigerian poetry include: imagery drawn from the Nigerian environment (rain, harmattan, river, forest, market, palm tree); borrowing of oral forms such as dirge, praise song, chant and proverb; themes of nature, death, love, exile, protest, war and the condition of the poor; the use of local names and allusions; and varying difficulty, from the obscure and highly modernist (Okigbo, early Soyinka) to the plain and communal (Osundare, Ofeimun).

9.5 Themes in Nigerian literature

Theme	Where it appears	How writers treat it
Colonial encounter and culture conflict	Achebe's early novels; Rotimi's historical plays	Tragic: the proud person broken by change
Corruption and political failure	A Man of the People; Kongi's Harvest; many poems	Satire, irony, caricature
Tradition versus modernity	The Lion and the Jewel; Okara's poems	Comedy or tension between old and new
Fate, destiny and the supernatural	The Concubine; The Gods Are Not to Blame	Tragedy, with attention to oracle and omen
Women's experience	Efuru; The Joys of Motherhood; Purple Hibiscus	Realism, sympathy, protest against restriction
War and its cost	Half of a Yellow Sun; Okigbo; war poems	Realism, elegy, witness
Religion and faith	Arrow of God; Brother Jero; Purple Hibiscus	Conflict between creeds; satire of hypocrisy
Poverty, oil and environment	Niger Delta poetry; recent novels	Protest, lament, documentary detail

9.6 Language and style in Nigerian writing

Nigerian writers, writing in English, make the language their own. They use **proverbs** (an elder reproaches a quarrelsome son with the saying that when a child washes his hands he may eat with elders, but when he

swallows the elder's meat he is in trouble); **transliteration** (literal rendering of local idiom into English, for example "he did not have the mouth to refuse"); **Nigerian Pidgin**, which places urban, uneducated or comic characters; **code-mixing** with Yoruba, Igbo or Hausa words; **songs and chants**; and **narration that echoes the storyteller**. A passage may combine a formal, controlled narrator with sharply colloquial speech, and the difference shows class and attitude. Achebe's narrator is calm and ironic; Soyinka's language is dense and poetic; Ekwensi's is quick and journalistic; Okigbo's is rich with symbol and sound; Osundare's is simple and rhythmic.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.2

In an original scene, a politician, Chief Ladipo, tells a crowd, "I have come among you like the rain", while his driver quietly collects bags of rice meant for the clinic into the car boot. Name two devices and explain the effect.

Solution: 1. The politician's statement is a **simile** comparing himself with life-giving rain. 2. The action of the driver reveals **irony**: the speaker claims to give life, while he takes from the poor, and the audience's knowledge of the theft makes it **dramatic irony**. 3. The effect is satirical: the writer exposes the gap between public promise and private greed, a theme of political satire in Nigerian drama and prose.

9.7 Reading Nigerian texts for the examination

A systematic approach to a prescribed Nigerian text should cover the following headings, and a short written note under each is the best form of revision.

- **Author and background:** the writer's dates, ethnic and regional background, and place in literary history.
- **Summary of plot:** the main episodes in order, with beginning, complication, climax and resolution.
- **Setting:** time, place, social conditions, and how the setting affects events.
- **Characters:** the protagonist, antagonist, major and minor characters, their strengths and flaws, and how they change.
- **Themes:** principal and secondary, with at least one episode that illustrates each.
- **Style and language:** narrative voice, proverbs, imagery, symbols, irony, diction.
- **Relevance:** what the text says about Nigerian society, then and now.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.3

A Nigerian play opens with an elder drummer calling the village to the square, and closes with the same drum, now silent, as the square empties. Comment on this structure.

Solution: 1. This is a circular or framing structure, with an opening and a closing image that match. 2. The drum, a traditional instrument of summons and community, is a symbol of communal life. 3. Its silence at the end suggests that the community has been broken or silenced during the action. 4. The change from call to silence conveys tragedy and loss without direct statement. 5. The device draws on oral performance traditions in which the drum opens and ends a story.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.4

A candidate is asked, "Discuss the role of women in a Nigerian novel you have read." Outline a good answer in four points.

Solution: 1. State the text and its period. 2. Describe the women's roles (wife, mother, trader, daughter) and the limits placed on them, with named characters and episodes. 3. Show how the writer judges the situation, through sympathy, irony or protest, and give evidence from the text. 4. Conclude by connecting the portrayal to wider issues such as marriage customs, education or economic independence. A complete answer must be anchored in your own text, so each point needs a specific example.

Exercise 9.1

1. The author of *Things Fall Apart* is (A) Wole Soyinka (B) Chinua Achebe (C) Ola Rotimi (D) Cyprian Ekwensi.
2. Which Nigerian writer won the Nobel Prize in Literature, and in which year?
3. Name the author of *The Gods Are Not to Blame* and say which type of play it is.
4. Write the name of the author of *The Concubine* and state one theme.
5. Which poet, killed in the Nigerian civil war, is the author of *Heavensgate*?
6. Match the writer with the genre or concern: Ekwensi, Nwapa, Osundare. (urban life, women's trading life, poetry of the common man)

Answers to Exercise 9.1

1. (B): Chinua Achebe wrote it in 1958.
2. Wole Soyinka, in 1986.
3. Ola Rotimi; it is a tragedy (an adaptation of the Greek Oedipus story into a Yoruba setting).
4. Elechi Amadi; themes include fate, supernatural belief and the conflict between love and the will of a god.
5. Christopher Okigbo (1932–1967).

6. Ekwensi: urban life; Nwapa: women's trading life; Osundare: poetry of the common man.

Exercise 9.2

1. Name two techniques Nigerian novelists borrow from oral tradition.
2. Explain why Lakunle in *The Lion and the Jewel* is a comic figure, in one or two sentences.
3. What is the significance of "Piano and Drums" by Gabriel Okara in the theme of culture conflict? Answer in two sentences.
4. Contrast the language of Achebe and Okigbo in one sentence.
5. Give two features of Niyi Osundare's poetry.
6. Read: "The elders sat in silence, and the proverb they did not speak weighed more than the ones they did." What is the effect of the writer's choice?

Answers to Exercise 9.2

1. Any two: proverbs, folktales, songs, chants, a storyteller narrator, repetition and refrain, call and response.
2. He is infatuated with Western manners and speaks in an inflated, bookish way, yet misunderstands his own village, so the audience laughs at his pretensions.

3. The poem contrasts the natural pulse of the drum with the complex piano, representing the pull between African tradition and Western culture; the speaker is caught between them.
4. Achebe's language is plain, restrained and proverbial; Okigbo's is dense, symbolic and musical.
5. Plain accessible diction rooted in oral forms; public and political concern for the common man, with imagery from the Nigerian landscape.
6. The silence conveys heavy, unspoken meaning, creating suspense and showing that the elders' authority lies partly in restraint; it also reflects the importance of the proverb in the culture.

Chapter summary

- Nigerian literature began in many oral traditions and entered the novel in English in the 1950s, passing through independence, civil war, military rule and a contemporary period.
- Prose: Tutuola (folk fantasy), Ekwensi (urban), Achebe (history and politics), Amadi (fate), Nwapa and Emecheta (women), Okri, Adichie, Habila and Obioma (later generation).
- Drama: Soyinka, Clark, Rotimi, Osofisan and Sofola draw on ritual, myth, dance, proverb and satire, and often use tragic form.
- Poetry: Okigbo, Soyinka, Clark and Okara (first generation); Osundare, Ofeimun and Ojaide (second); Raji, Ifowodo and

others (younger).

- Principal themes are culture conflict, corruption, tradition versus modernity, fate, women's experience, war, religion and poverty.
- Nigerian writers adapt English with proverbs, transliteration, Pidgin, songs and storyteller narration.
- Revise each text under author, plot, setting, characters, themes and style, with specific episodes as evidence.

Chapter 10: Non-African Literature: British, American and Caribbean Writing

The Literature in English syllabus does not confine the candidate to the African continent. Alongside the novels, plays and poems of Africa, the examination expects a working knowledge of the wider English-language tradition: the drama of the Greeks and of Shakespeare, the poetry of England from Chaucer to the modern age, the novel as it developed in Britain, the literature of the United States, and the vigorous writing of the Caribbean. This is not an arbitrary requirement. English is the medium in which Nigerian writers themselves were educated, and many of the forms they use (the sonnet, the tragic play, the realist novel) came to them through this tradition, which they then adapted, challenged or answered. To understand Wole Soyinka's tragedy, or Chinua Achebe's reply to Joseph Conrad, you must know what was being adapted or answered.

This chapter is a map rather than a library. It tells you who the principal writers are, in which period they wrote, what they characteristically wrote about, and which techniques define them. As in earlier chapters, the remarks on named works are accurate general summaries meant to supply the background that questions assume; the set books you have been assigned must be read directly and closely. All the sample passages below are original compositions written for teaching.

10.1 Why period and movement matter

Literature in English is conventionally divided into periods, each with its own preoccupations. A *period* is a stretch of time; a *movement* is a group of writers who share an outlook and a manner. Recognising the period of a text lets you predict much of its content before you read a line. The following table summarises the divisions that matter most for the examination.

Period (approximate)	Typical concerns	Representative writers
Classical Greek (5th century BC)	Fate, the gods, the fall of great persons, civic duty	Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides
Medieval (14th century)	Religion, social types, storytelling	Geoffrey Chaucer
Renaissance (16th to early 17th century)	Ambition, human potential, love, kingship, revenge	Marlowe, Shakespeare, Donne, Milton
Eighteenth century (Augustan)	Reason, order, satire, manners	Swift, Pope, Defoe
Romantic (about 1790 to 1830)	Nature, feeling, imagination, the individual	Blake, Wordsworth, Coleridge, Keats, Shelley
Victorian (1837 to 1901)	Industrial society, class, morality, doubt	Dickens, the Brontë sisters, Hardy, Tennyson, Browning
Modern (early to mid 20th century)	Fragmentation, war, disillusion, experiment	Eliot, Yeats, Conrad, Auden, Orwell
Contemporary and postcolonial	Identity, race, empire and its aftermath, migration	Walcott, Naipaul, Morrison, Rushdie

Key point. When a question asks you to "place" a poem or novel, do not merely name a century. Say what the period believed and show how the text reflects it: a Romantic poem exalts feeling and nature; an Augustan one prizes balance and wit; a modernist one broken and allusive.

10.2 Drama: from Athens to Elizabethan London

Greek tragedy

European drama begins in the religious festivals of ancient Athens. The three great tragedians whose plays survive are Aeschylus, Sophocles and Euripides. Greek tragedy had a *chorus*, a group of citizens who commented on the action in song and movement, and it observed a rough unity of time, place and action. In his *Poetics* the philosopher Aristotle analysed tragedy and left the vocabulary that critics still use: *hamartia* (the error or flaw that brings the hero down), *peripeteia* (the reversal of fortune), *anagnorisis* (the moment of recognition) and *catharsis* (the purging of pity and fear in the audience). Sophocles' *Oedipus the King* is the model case. The king of Thebes searches for the murderer who has brought plague upon the city, and discovers that he himself is the man; recognition and reversal come together in one terrible scene. Sophocles' *Antigone* sets the claim of family and conscience against the decree of the ruler, a conflict that has been staged in many languages, including Nigerian adaptations.

Shakespeare

William Shakespeare (1564 to 1616) wrote for the public playhouses of London, above all the Globe. His tragedies are the plays most often prescribed. In *Hamlet* a Danish prince, charged by his father's ghost to avenge a murder, is held back by doubt and conscience; the play's chief interest lies in his hesitation and in the soliloquies through which we

enter his mind. In *Macbeth* a general who has served his king faithfully is tempted by a prophecy and by his wife's urging to murder Duncan; ambition, guilt and the corrosion of the self are the themes, and the imagery of blood, darkness and sleeplessness gives the play its atmosphere. *Othello* shows a noble commander destroyed by jealousy that his subordinate Iago deliberately inflames; the play is a study of how easily trust can be poisoned. *Julius Caesar* treats political violence and the problem of the honourable man who commits a crime for the sake of the state. Among the comedies, *The Merchant of Venice* contrasts mercy with the strict letter of the law, in the figures of Portia and the moneylender Shylock.

Shakespeare's technique is worth summarising, for a question on any play may ask about it.

- **Blank verse.** Unrhymed iambic pentameter, the natural medium of the noble characters; humbler speakers often use prose, so a shift from verse to prose is itself meaningful.
- **Soliloquy and aside.** A soliloquy reveals a character alone with his thoughts; an aside gives a brief remark to the audience unheard by others.
- **Comic relief.** A light or coarse scene placed within a tragedy, such as the porter's scene in *Macbeth*, relaxes tension and sharpens the contrast with the horror around it.
- **Dramatic irony.** The audience knows what the speaker does not; in *Othello* we know Iago's honesty is a mask while the hero trusts it.

- **Foil.** A character who throws another into relief: Banquo's integrity highlights Macbeth's fall.

> **Key point.** A Shakespearean tragedy follows a recognisable arc: a noble protagonist with a flaw, a temptation or provocation, a gradual descent, a crisis, and a final death that restores order to the state. If you can state the flaw, the crisis and the restoration for each prescribed tragedy, you can answer most structural questions.

10.3 Poetry in the English tradition

English poetry is a long conversation across centuries, and the main stations of that conversation each leave their mark on the forms you studied in Chapter 5.

- **Chaucer** (about 1343 to 1400) is the father of English poetry. His *Canterbury Tales* presents pilgrims travelling to a shrine who tell stories to pass the time; the General Prologue is a gallery of social types portrayed with humour and gentle irony.
- **The Renaissance lyric.** Shakespeare's 154 sonnets use the English (Shakespearean) form of three quatrains and a couplet, rhyming *abab cdcd efef gg*, to treat love, time and beauty. John Donne and the metaphysical poets use the *conceit*, an elaborate, startling comparison, and a conversational, argumentative tone. John Milton's

Paradise Lost (1667) is a Christian epic in blank verse on the fall of humankind.

- **The Augustans.** Alexander Pope perfected the heroic couplet and the mock-epic. Jonathan Swift turned satire on human folly.
- **The Romantics.** William Blake contrasted innocence and experience in plain-seeming but symbolic songs. William Wordsworth sought the "language of ordinary men" and found meaning in nature and memory; Samuel Taylor Coleridge explored the supernatural; John Keats pursued beauty in odes of sensuous richness; Percy Bysshe Shelley wrote of liberty and change.
- **The Victorians.** Alfred Tennyson gave a polished music to doubt and loss; Robert Browning perfected the dramatic monologue, in which a speaker unwittingly reveals his own character; Gerard Manley Hopkins experimented with "sprung rhythm" and compressed, vivid diction; Thomas Hardy wrote bleakly of fate and the passing of time.
- **The moderns.** W. B. Yeats moved from Irish legend to a symbolic poetry of historical crisis; T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922) used fragments, quotation and many voices to portray a civilisation in disarray; W. H. Auden brought a conversational, political intelligence to verse.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.1

Read this original poem and identify its period tendency.

The river keeps its quiet hour; / the hills lean in to hear; / I walk, and feel a gentle power / that makes the heart less drear. / No crowded street, no counting-room / has taught me what I find / where evening scatters its perfume / and soothes the troubled mind.

Solution: Notice first what the poem is about: a walker finds comfort and instruction in a natural setting at evening. The speaker contrasts nature ("the quiet hour", "the hills") with commerce ("crowded street", "counting-room"), and claims that nature teaches more than the city. Personification ("the hills lean in to hear") gives landscape a living attention. The stance is individual and emotional, the diction simple, the form a regular ballad stanza. These are the marks of Romantic poetry, which prized nature, feeling and the solitary observer, and valued spontaneous emotion over formal wit. Answer: Romantic in outlook, in the tradition of Wordsworth.

10.4 The English novel

The novel rose in the eighteenth century with the growth of a reading middle class. *Daniel Defoe's Robinson Crusoe* (1719) is often called the first English novel, an account of survival and self-reliance whose colonial assumptions later writers, including Caribbean and African

ones, would question. Jonathan Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) is a satire in the form of travellers' tales. In the early nineteenth century, *Jane Austen* perfected the comedy of manners: *Pride and Prejudice* (1813) studies courtship, class and self-knowledge with an ironic, finely balanced prose.

The Victorian age was the novel's golden age. Charles Dickens wrote of poverty, hypocrisy and injustice in crowded, comic, sentimental prose; *Great Expectations* (1861) follows an orphan, Pip, whose ambition to become a gentleman brings him shame before it brings him wisdom, and *Hard Times* (1854) attacks an education and an economy that reduce human beings to facts and figures. Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre* (1847) gives a governess's passionate claim to dignity and independence. Thomas Hardy portrays rural people crushed by fate and social convention in novels such as *Tess of the d'Urbervilles.*

In the twentieth century the novel turned inward and experimented. *Joseph Conrad's Heart of Darkness* (1899) tells of a journey up an African river through a narrator within a narrator; Chinua Achebe's 1975 lecture on the novel accused it of treating Africa as a backdrop for European moral crisis, a judgement that remains the most famous act of postcolonial criticism. George Orwell's *Animal Farm* (1945) is an allegory of revolution betrayed, and his *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) a dystopia of surveillance and lies. William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) asks what becomes of a group of schoolboys stranded without adult rule, and answers that civilisation is a fragile covering over savagery.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.2

A novel tells of farm animals who overthrow a cruel owner, only for their pig leaders to become as harsh as the man they replaced. What kind of work is this, and what is its central theme?

Solution: The surface narrative is about animals, but each animal and event stands for something outside the story: the pigs for a ruling clique, the other animals for the common people, the rebellion for a revolution. A story whose characters and events carry a sustained second meaning is an *allegory*; when its purpose is to mock a political system or abuse of power it is also a *satire*. The central theme is the corruption of power and the betrayal of revolutionary ideals. Answer: a political allegory and satire, on the corruption of power.

10.5 American literature

American writing grows from the New World's own history: the frontier, slavery and its legacy, immigration, and the pursuit of a promised prosperity. Mark Twain's *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (1884) uses a boy's vernacular voice to expose the hypocrisy of a society that tolerates slavery. Ernest Hemingway's spare, understated style, shaped by his belief that dignity shows in how a person endures loss, marks *The Old Man and the Sea* (1952), the story of an aged fisherman's struggle with a great fish. John Steinbeck's *Of Mice and Men* (1937) shows the fragile dreams of migrant workers in the Depression. In drama, Arthur Miller's

Death of a Salesman (1949) questions the cost of chasing success, and Lorraine Hansberry's *A Raisin in the Sun* (1959) portrays a black family in Chicago holding to its hopes.

African-American writing deserves special attention for the Nigerian reader because of its kinship with African themes. The Harlem Renaissance of the 1920s produced Langston Hughes, whose short, jazz-inflected poems celebrate black life with pride and sorrow; later Maya Angelou told her life in autobiography, and Toni Morrison, in *Beloved* (1987), wrote of slavery's memory and its haunting of the living. Alex Haley's *Roots* traced a family back to West Africa, linking the diaspora to the continent.

10.6 Caribbean literature

The Caribbean islands share with Africa a history of plantation slavery, colonial rule and the struggle for independence, and their writers face the same question of language: how to write truthfully in the colonisers' tongue. Derek Walcott of Saint Lucia (Nobel Prize 1992) combined classical reference with island speech, most ambitiously in the long poem *Omeros* (1990). Edward Kamau Brathwaite of Barbados made use of "nation language", the rhythms of Caribbean speech and music, in his verse. V. S. Naipaul, born in Trinidad, wrote of rootlessness and failed ambition in *A House for Mr Biswas* (1961). George Lamming, from Barbados, examined colonial education in *In the Castle of My Skin*. The common thread is the reclaiming of identity from the shadow of empire, which is why Caribbean and African texts are so often studied together.

10.7 Techniques that cross cultures

Whatever the region, the same toolkit appears. Students who notice this can answer comparative questions with confidence.

Feature	In non-African texts	In African and Nigerian texts
Language	Standard or regional English, dialect for realism	English with proverbs, pidgin and translated idiom
Tragedy	Individual flaw and fate	Individual flaw, but also the clash of communal values and change
Satire	Manners, politics, institutions	Corrupt leadership and the postcolonial elite
Setting	Court, city, countryside, frontier	Village, city, the contested colonial space

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.3

Read this original speech from a play and name the device and its effect.

KING. *(alone, to the audience)* They call me just; the people bless my name; / but who has seen the hours I lie awake / and count the faces that I have to fear?

Solution: The king speaks alone, addressing no one on stage and turning to the audience. This is a *soliloquy*. It lets the audience hear what the public never hears, the fear behind the praise. The contrast between "they call me just" and "faces that I have to fear" exposes a gap between reputation and reality, so the passage also builds *dramatic irony*, since the people on stage believe in a just king while we know otherwise. The effect is to deepen our sympathy and our unease. Answer: soliloquy; it reveals hidden thoughts and sets up dramatic irony.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.4

A student writes: "Both Macbeth and Okonkwo are tragic heroes." Explain the basis of this claim and give one difference.

Solution: Both are men of high standing and real achievement whose own character brings them down. Macbeth's flaw is ambition driven past conscience; Okonkwo's, in Achebe's novel, is a fear of weakness that hardens into violence. Each suffers a reversal, recognises too late what he has lost, and dies, one by the sword and one by his own hand. The difference lies in the surrounding force. Macbeth falls chiefly through personal choices and a supernatural prompting; Okonkwo's fall is also shaped by the arrival of a colonial order that breaks his world. Answer: similarity of heroic stature, flaw and fall; difference in the weight of communal and historical forces.

10.8 Studying non-African texts for the examination

Three habits give the strongest results. First, always connect a technique to a meaning: do not say "the poet uses a metaphor" but "the metaphor of the sea as a grave shows the speaker's fear." Second, know the outline of your prescribed text precisely, including its characters' names, its sequence of events and its ending, since the multiple-choice questions

test these. Third, when a passage is printed, read it twice before answering: once for sense, once for manner. Look at the first and last lines, the verbs, the repeated words and any shift of tone.

Exercise 10.1

1. Name the Greek philosopher who analysed tragedy in the *Poetics*.
2. What is the term for the flaw or error that brings a tragic hero down?
3. Which verse form is used for most of Shakespeare's tragedies?
4. How many lines does a Shakespearean sonnet have, and how does it end?
5. A character speaks his thoughts aloud while alone on stage. What is this device called?
6. Which Romantic poet is associated with the claim that poetry should use the language of ordinary speech?
7. Who wrote *Animal Farm*, and what kind of work is it?
8. Name the writer, from Saint Lucia, who won the Nobel Prize in 1992.
9. Which Nigerian writer criticised Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* in a famous lecture?
10. A speaker in a poem unintentionally reveals his own cruel character while describing something else. Which Victorian poetic form does this describe?

11. Name the movement of the 1920s associated with Langston Hughes.
12. State two ways in which Caribbean and African literature resemble each other.

Answers to Exercise 10.1

1. Aristotle, who wrote the *Poetics*.
2. Hamartia (the tragic flaw).
3. Blank verse, which is unrhymed iambic pentameter.
4. Fourteen lines, ending in a rhyming couplet.
5. A soliloquy.
6. William Wordsworth.
7. George Orwell; it is a political allegory and satire.
8. Derek Walcott.
9. Chinua Achebe.
10. The dramatic monologue, perfected by Robert Browning.
11. The Harlem Renaissance.
12. Both have histories of slavery or colonial rule and the struggle for independence; both writers must decide how to use the colonisers' language to express local life.

Chapter summary

- English-language literature divides into periods, each with typical concerns: Renaissance ambition, Augustan order, Romantic feeling, Victorian social conscience, modern fragmentation.
- Greek tragedy supplied the vocabulary of hamartia, peripeteia, anagnorisis and catharsis; Shakespeare's tragedies use blank verse, soliloquy, comic relief and dramatic irony.
- English poetry runs from Chaucer through the sonnet and the metaphysical conceit to Romantic nature poetry, the Victorian dramatic monologue and modernist experiment.
- The novel moved from Defoe and Austen to Dickens and the Brontës, then to the allegory and dystopia of Orwell and the fable of Golding.
- American writing explores the frontier, race and the cost of success; Caribbean writers reclaim identity from empire through island speech.
- Always tie a technique to its effect on meaning, and know the plot and characters of every prescribed text.

Chapter 11: Literary Appreciation and Criticism

Every earlier chapter of this book has equipped you with knowledge: what a sonnet is, how a narrator sees, what irony does, which authors belong to which tradition. This final chapter teaches you what to do with that knowledge when a text is placed before you. Literary appreciation is the skill of reading a passage or poem closely and explaining, in orderly and evidence-based prose, what it says, how it says it, and why it works. Literary criticism is the wider activity of judging and interpreting literature, and it has its own schools, each asking different questions of the same text. The examination tests both. Multiple-choice items about an unseen poem or passage test appreciation; items about the approach a critic takes, or about a writer's social purpose, test criticism.

A candidate who has this skill does not panic at an unfamiliar poem. He or she has a method, applies it in the same order every time, and finds that the text begins to answer. The chapter sets out that method in full, shows it at work on original passages, describes the principal critical approaches, and ends with advice on the pitfalls that cost marks. All the passages used here were composed for this book.

11.1 What appreciation means

To appreciate a text is not merely to like it. It is to understand its meaning and to recognise the means by which that meaning is created. Two questions govern all appreciation. The first is *what*: what is the passage about, who is speaking, what happens, what feeling is conveyed? The second is *how*: by what choices of words, images, sounds, structure and voice does the writer produce this effect? A good answer joins the two. To say a poem "is about death" answers only the first question. To say that the poem treats death calmly because its steady rhythm, plain diction and gentle image of an evening fading all suggest acceptance answers both.

> **Key point.** Appreciation always rests on evidence. Every claim about meaning or effect must point to a word, phrase, device or feature of the text. A statement with no textual support is an opinion, not an analysis.

11.2 A method for appreciating poetry

The steps below should be followed in order. With practice they can be run through in a minute or two for a short poem.

1. **Read the title and the whole poem once for sense.** Ask who is speaking, to whom, about what, and on what occasion.

2. **State the subject and the theme.** The *subject* is what the poem is about (a mother's market stall); the *theme* is the idea it explores (sacrifice, endurance, the dignity of labour).
3. **Identify the tone and mood.** *Tone* is the speaker's attitude to the subject (admiring, bitter, ironic, tender); *mood* is the atmosphere produced in the reader (peaceful, uneasy, sombre).
4. **Study the structure.** Note the number of stanzas, the rhyme scheme, the metre, where a line is enjambed, and where a shift (a *volta*) occurs in thought or tone.
5. **Examine diction.** Are the words simple or elevated, concrete or abstract, harsh or soft? Do they belong to a particular field, such as war, farming or religion?
6. **Examine imagery and figures of speech.** Identify simile, metaphor, personification, symbol, irony and so on, and always say what each contributes.
7. **Examine sound and rhythm.** Look for alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia, repetition and the movement of the lines.
8. **Judge the overall effect.** Say what the poem leaves the reader feeling or thinking, and whether the technique has been successful.

WORKED EXAMPLE 11.1

Appreciate this original poem.

Harmattan

She comes in December, dry-lipped and grey, / and strips the mango tree to its bones; / the morning hangs its blanket of haze / on rooftops, roads and silent stones. // The children cough, the farmers wait, / the dust drifts in at every door; / yet somewhere underneath the weight / the rains are gathering once more.

Solution: **Subject.** The poem describes the harmattan, the dry dust-laden wind of the Nigerian dry season. **Theme.** The theme is endurance and hope: hardship is real but temporary, because rain will return. **Tone and mood.** The tone is calm and observant, accepting rather than complaining; the mood in the first stanza is bleak and in the second turns quietly hopeful. **Structure.** Two quatrains, each rhyming *abab*: in the first stanza bones/stones is a full rhyme and grey/haze a slant rhyme; in the second, wait/weight and door/more are full rhymes. The decisive point is the shift at "yet" in line 7, which turns the poem from description of hardship to expectation of renewal. **Diction and imagery.** The harmattan is personified as a woman ("She comes", "dry-lipped and grey"), so the season is treated as a visitor with a character. The metaphor "strips the mango tree to its bones" suggests starkness and near-death, while "blanket of haze" is a gentle metaphor suggesting a covering that both hides and shelters. **Sound.** The hard consonants in "dry-lipped", "dust" and "drifts"

give a parched feel, and alliteration in "dust drifts" imitates the movement of the wind. **Effect.** The poem teaches patience: its quiet closing image of rains "gathering" turns a season of discomfort into a stage in a cycle of renewal.

11.3 Appreciating a prose passage

The method for prose has the same spirit but different details. First establish the **situation**: who is in the passage, where are they, what is happening, and where does it fall within the story if that is known? Next identify the **point of view** (first person, third person, omniscient or limited) and the **narrative voice** (reflective, comic, detached, indignant). Then examine **characterisation**: what do the descriptions, speech and actions reveal about a person? Look at **setting and atmosphere**, which often mirror mood; at **style**, meaning sentence length, vocabulary, use of dialogue, and presence of irony, imagery or symbolism; and finally the **theme** and the effect upon the reader.

Sentence structure repays attention. Short sentences in succession create tension, speed or bluntness; long sentences with many clauses suggest reflection, accumulation or confusion. A shift from long to short can mark a moment of shock. Dialogue can show social background, because a character who speaks in formal English, in pidgin, or in a mixture says something about education, class and situation. Lastly, notice what the writer leaves unsaid. Much of the best prose works by suggestion, and the observant reader supplies what is implied.

WORKED EXAMPLE 11.2

Read this original passage and answer the questions below.

Mama Kemi had sold akara at the junction for thirty years. She did not look up when the new officer arrived with his notebook and his important shoes. "Your permit, madam," he said. She turned a ball of bean paste in the oil and watched it brown. "Which permit?" she asked, as though enquiring about the weather. The officer coughed. Behind him, a queue of schoolchildren had begun to smile.

(a) Identify the point of view. (b) What does the passage reveal about Mama Kemi? (c) What is the effect of the final sentence?

Solution: (a) The passage is in the third person, with a narrator who observes both characters from outside and records outward behaviour; it is not told by either speaker. (b) Mama Kemi is calm, experienced and quietly defiant. Her thirty years at the junction suggest belonging and authority born of long presence; the verbs "did not look up", "turned" and "watched" show her unhurried control, and her question "Which permit?" is delivered with feigned innocence. (c) The final sentence shifts the focus to the children, whose smiles show where the sympathy of the crowd lies. It deflates the officer's importance, already hinted at by his "important shoes", an ironic phrase that mocks his self-regard. The passage is therefore gently humorous and comic in tone, with its satire directed at petty officialdom.

11.4 Appreciating a dramatic passage

A play exists to be performed, so appreciation of a dramatic extract must consider speech and action together. Identify who is speaking, to whom and in whose hearing; look for stage directions, which indicate gesture and movement; judge how the dialogue reveals character and moves the plot; and note techniques such as aside, soliloquy, irony, suspense and comic relief. Observe the *subtext*, the unstated meaning beneath what characters say. When a husband says "I am not angry" in a clipped voice, the words mean one thing and the delivery another. Notice also the pace: short, quick exchanges (*stichomythia*, in its classical form) create conflict and urgency, while a long speech slows the action to allow reflection or rhetoric.

WORKED EXAMPLE 11.3

Read this original extract.

ADE: *(not looking up from his ledger)* You are late again.
TUNDE: The road was bad.
ADE: The road is always bad.
TUNDE: Then I should always leave earlier.
ADE: Yes. *(He closes the ledger slowly.)* You should.

What does the extract show about the relationship, and how?

Solution: The brief, clipped lines (a form of stichomythia) create tension, and the repeated "always" accuses without raising the voice. Ade's refusal to look up shows that he holds authority and signals displeasure; the slow closing of the ledger is a stage action that tells us he is about to say something serious. Tunde's quiet reply is respectful but faintly resistant. The subtext is a quarrel under control: employer and employee, one irritated, one defensive. The extract works by what is held back rather than shouted. Answer: a strained, hierarchical relationship conveyed through terse dialogue, stage business and subtext.

11.5 The language of appreciation: tone, mood and diction

Candidates often confuse the words used to label tone. A short vocabulary helps. A *solemn* tone is serious and dignified; *nostalgic* looks back wistfully; *sardonic* is bitterly mocking; *satirical* ridicules for the sake of correction; *reflective* thinks quietly; *elegiac* mourns; *jubilant* rejoices; *apathetic* shows no concern; *didactic* teaches or instructs. Mood terms include *tense*, *serene*, *melancholic*, *ominous* and *festive*. When you choose a label, test it against the passage: does a specific word or image justify it?

Diction means a writer's chosen vocabulary. It may be *formal* or *colloquial*, *concrete* (naming things you can see and touch) or *abstract* (naming ideas), *archaic* (old-fashioned) or *contemporary*. A poem built on monosyllables feels plain and direct; one using long Latinate words feels grave and learned. *Connotation*, the associations that cling to a word, matters as much as its dictionary meaning. "Slender" and "skinny" both mean thin, but the first flatters and the second does not; a writer's choice between them reveals attitude.

11.6 Literary criticism: the main approaches

Criticism asks what a text means and what it is worth, and different critics begin from different assumptions. The schools below are those the syllabus and the better examination questions expect you to recognise.

Approach	Central question	Example of use
Formalist (or New Criticism)	How do form, language and structure create meaning, without reference to the author's life?	Studying how rhyme and imagery unify a poem
Historical and sociological	How does the work reflect its period and society?	Reading a colonial-era novel as a record of cultural conflict
Biographical	How does the author's life explain the work?	Linking a poet's exile to the loneliness in his verse
Moral (or didactic)	What values does the work teach, and are they sound?	Judging a fable by its lesson on greed
Marxist	How do class and economic power shape the story?	Examining the rich and the poor in a satire of corruption
Feminist	How are women represented, and whose voices are silenced?	Asking why a wife in a play has no independent action
Psychoanalytic	What do the characters' hidden motives and drives reveal?	Reading a hero's guilt as an unconscious conflict
Postcolonial	How does the text represent empire, race and cultural identity?	Achebe's critique of Conrad, or a study of language choice
Reader-response	How does the reader help create meaning?	Comparing how different readers respond to an ending
Archetypal (or myth)	What universal patterns, such as the journey or the scapegoat, recur?	Reading a hero's quest as a rite of passage

Key point. No approach is a complete answer. Each illuminates part of a work and neglects another. The strongest essays combine them: a formalist account of how a poem is built, joined with a historical account of the situation that provoked it.

WORKED EXAMPLE 11.4

A critic argues that a novel about a village chief and a colonial district officer is best read as a record of how two systems of authority met and collided. Which approach is this, and what would a formalist reply?

Solution: The critic reads the novel through the history and society that produced it and the cultural conflict it depicts, so the approach is historical and sociological, with postcolonial concerns as well. A formalist would reply that the real value lies in how the novel is constructed (its plot, its narrator's detachment, its proverbs, its irony) and would judge it by the unity and force of these elements, not by the history that lies behind them. Neither reading cancels the other. Answer: historical-sociological (postcolonial); the formalist stresses form and language over context.

11.7 Evaluation: judging a work

Appreciation moves naturally to evaluation. A competent critic asks whether a work is *coherent* (do its parts fit?), *convincing* (are the characters and events believable within the world of the text?), *original* (does it say something freshly?), *significant* (does it deal with matters that count?), and *skilful* (is its language precise and economical?). The test of a judgment is not whether you agree with the writer but whether you can justify your view with reference to the text. A student may find a novel's ending abrupt, provided he shows how the abruptness leaves a plot thread untied; he may find it powerful, provided he shows how its brevity enacts the character's shock.

Be careful with the words *didactic* and *propaganda*. A work with a social purpose is not weak for having one; many of the finest satires and protest poems in African literature are didactic. The difficulty arises only when the message overwhelms the art, so that characters become mouthpieces and the language goes slack. Equally, avoid the lazy judgment that a work is good because it is "interesting" or "realistic". Say which features make it so.

11.8 Writing and answering well

In essay or objective questions alike, three working habits earn marks. First, follow the sequence *point, evidence, explanation*. State what you are claiming (the poet uses nature to suggest hope), give the textual proof (the phrase "rains are gathering"), and explain how the proof

supports the claim. Second, quote sparingly. A short phrase of two to six words, built into your own sentence, is more convincing than a long copied line. Third, keep your own comment above the level of paraphrase; retelling the passage in plain words is not appreciation.

The most frequent errors are easily listed. Candidates *name devices without effect*, writing "there is alliteration" and stopping. They *confuse subject with theme*, giving the topic when the idea was asked for. They *misjudge tone* by reading every poem as sad. They *ignore the title*, which often supplies the key. They *over-read*, building a large theory on a single word, or *under-read*, missing the irony of a line meant to be comic. In objective papers, the discipline of reading every option before choosing, and of eliminating those the text contradicts, is worth several marks.

Key point. When you meet an unseen passage, read it twice, decide who speaks and what is happening, fix the tone, and only then turn to the questions. Answers drawn from a clear overall understanding are more accurate than answers hunted line by line.

Exercise 11.1

1. Distinguish between the subject and the theme of a poem, with a short example.
2. Define tone, and say how it differs from mood.

3. Read: *"The clerk filed the complaint under D, for Delay, and went to lunch."* State the tone and give your reason.
4. Which critical approach examines how a work reflects the class struggle and economic power?
5. A critic ignores the author's life and studies only the poem's form and language. Name the approach.
6. What is the term for the unstated meaning beneath what characters say in a play?
7. In the poem "Harmattan" above, which word marks the shift from hardship to hope?
8. Explain the difference between connotation and denotation, using "slender" and "skinny".
9. A passage uses a series of very short sentences during a robbery. What effect is likely?
10. A critic asks why the women in a play speak so little and have no power to decide. Which approach is this?
11. Name two qualities by which a critic may judge a work to be successful.
12. Write three sentences appreciating this original couplet: *"The lamp burns low, the market's done; / the last of the day's own voices run."*

Answers to Exercise 11.1

1. The subject is what the poem is about (for example, a farmer at harvest); the theme is the idea it explores (for example, the reward of patient labour).
2. Tone is the writer's or speaker's attitude to the subject; mood is the atmosphere created in the reader. A poem may have a mocking tone yet leave a sombre mood.
3. Ironic or satirical (also wryly comic): the offhand filing under "Delay" and the leisurely lunch mock the clerk's indifference to a complaint.
4. The Marxist approach.
5. The formalist approach (New Criticism).
6. Subtext.
7. "Yet" (line 7).
8. Denotation is the dictionary meaning; connotation is the associated feeling. Both mean thin, but "slender" suggests grace and "skinny" suggests unattractive thinness.
9. Tension, speed and urgency, with a sense of shock or breathlessness.
10. The feminist approach.
11. Any two of coherence, believability, originality, significance and skill in language.
12. Sample: The couplet has a quiet, reflective tone and a mood of closing and calm. The "lamp burns low" and "market's done" are images of the day's end, suggesting tiredness and completion. The

rhyme of "done" and "run" binds the lines, and the sound of "voices" fading enacts the dying of the day's noise.

Chapter summary

- Appreciation answers two questions, what the text says and how it says it, and every claim must rest on textual evidence.
- Appreciate poetry in order: sense, subject and theme, tone and mood, structure, diction, imagery, sound, overall effect.
- For prose, examine situation, point of view, characterisation, setting, style and theme; for drama, add stage action, subtext and pace.
- Use tone words precisely (solemn, nostalgic, sardonic, elegiac, didactic) and test each against the words on the page.
- The main critical schools are formalist, historical-sociological, biographical, moral, Marxist, feminist, psychoanalytic, postcolonial, reader-response and archetypal; each asks a different question and none is complete.
- Judge a work by coherence, conviction, originality, significance and skill, and defend the judgment with evidence.
- Write in the pattern point, evidence, explanation; quote briefly; avoid naming devices without effect and confusing subject with theme.